

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mrs. Kamla Sansanwal has approached (CICI) Bank Ltd., Purnjabi Bagh, New Delhi. (CICI) Bank to avail a loan against mortgage of (CICI) Bank Plot No. 253, Ground Floor, Prasad Nagar, Phase-I, New Delhi-11005 (after release of the same from Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd) and has represented that she is the absolute owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 03.10.1979 (Doc. No. 8848) executed by Mr. Satish Kumar Sawhney. If anybody, person, body corporate (other than Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd) has any right, claim or claim whatsoever on the said property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it must contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same shall be waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

**Amit Kumar, Advocate
Narang & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.**

Satyendar Jain among six arrested in STP projects tender case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) on Tuesday arrested six accused, including former Delhi Water Minister Satyendar Kumar Jain and former Delhi Jal Board (DJB) CEO Udit Prakash Rai, in connection with a multi-crore scam involving the tendering process for upgrading Delhi Jal Board's sewage treatment plants.

The investigators traced the bribe money worth ₹1.52 crore to the bank accounts of the utility's former CEO.

"The tendering process allegedly involved restrictive technical specifications

favouring a particular technology provider, thereby restricting competition and providing undue advantage to a selected private entity," Joint Commissioner of Police Vikramjit Singh, head of the Anti-Corruption Branch, said in a statement announcing the arrests.

The other accused arrested are Ankit Srivastava, a former contractual consultant with the DJB, and private persons Nagendra Yadav, proprietor of AN Enterprises, Raja Kumar Kurra, owner of Euroteck Environment Pvt Ltd, and Pankaj Verma, proprietor of Srijanhar. The arrests were made in connection with an FIR registered in May 2024

under provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act and relevant IPC sections at the ACB police station. The case originated from a complaint by the Directorate of Vigilance, GNCTD, alleging large-scale irregularities and manipulation of tender conditions in the process of augmenting and upgrading DJB's sewage treatment plants.

According to ACB, the investigation found that the tendering process included restrictive technical conditions that favoured Euroteck Environment as the technology provider, effectively limiting competition.

Investigators found that a proposed pilot study was



Satyendar Kumar Jain

never conducted, restrictive conditions were included regarding the technology and media to be used, essential parameters for treated effluent were excluded, and technical specifications were

altered in ways that carried significant financial implications for the government.

The ACB said private individuals were allegedly in regular

contact with public servants and intermediaries to manipulate the tendering process. Electronic evidence examined during the investigation reportedly showed exchanges of restrictive tender conditions, corrigendums and other tender related documents that were later incorporated into DJB's official tender notice, pointing to what investigators described as a nexus between private persons and public officials.

The financial trail, according to ACB, showed funds moving through intermediary entities Srijanhar and AN Enterprises in the form of alleged commissions or bribes. Substantial amounts

were reportedly transferred to Nagendra Yadav's proprietorship firm from entities linked to the private technology provider, with further transfers reaching government officials, including former DJB CEO Udit Prakash Rai and his relatives.

Investigators found that Rai received bribes amounting to ₹1.52 crore in bank accounts belonging to him and his relatives, routed through AN Enterprises from Euroteck. The funds were allegedly used to purchase immovable property.

The probe also uncovered communications between Raja Kumar Kurra, Nagendra Yadav and Ankit Srivastava discussing meetings, tender

conditions and corrigendums related to the sewage treatment plant tender, indicating that restrictive conditions were introduced or modified specifically to favour Euroteck Environment. Based on the evidence gathered, all six accused were interrogated and arrested by the ACB on August 18, 2026, in accordance with law. The ACB said further investigation into the case, including the complete money trail and alleged proceeds of crime, remains in progress.

The arrests mark a significant development in the ACB's investigation into alleged corruption and irregularities in the Delhi Jal Board's STP tendering process.

Over 30-40% voters in 47 of 70 Delhi Assembly seats to be removed from draft rolls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Under the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Delhi's electoral rolls, more than 30-40 per cent of voters in 47 of the 70 assembly constituencies will be excluded from the draft electoral rolls to be published on August 24.

Constituencies with upscale areas such as Greater Kailash (35 per cent), Malviya Nagar (38.64 per cent), New Delhi (41.76 per cent) and RK Puram (44.46 per cent) show higher percentage of voters to be excluded from the draft rolls. In minority-dominated constituencies, voters accounting for 20 to 40 per cent of the electorate will be excluded from the draft electoral rolls.

More than 30 per cent electors were marked as "uncollectable", meaning either they did not submit their forms or they were shifted from their registered address, were dead or were duplicate electors. Another mixed



pattern was the economically upward Rajouri Garden constituency having one of the highest percentage (79.14) of digitised voter forms, whereas Tughlaqabad, having a rural setting, showed the lowest percentage (52.15) of digitised voter forms. In Tughlaqabad, around 48 per cent voters will be excluded from draft rolls of the constituency.

Data showed that some of the constituencies with extensive unauthorised colonies, resettlement areas and dense low-income or slum clusters recorded a lower percentage of voters to be excluded from draft rolls. Kirari has recorded 68.98

per cent digitisation, Sultan Pur Majra 68.93 per cent and Karawal Nagar 67.19 per cent.

Constituencies such as Mangol Puri, Uttam Nagar and Seelampur also showed digitisation above 76 per cent, while Bawana, Madipur, Narela and Matiala are in the 75-76 per cent range, implying relatively lesser percentage of voters to be excluded in the draft rolls.

Several constituencies in south and southeast Delhi remain below 60 per cent, including Kasturba Nagar (55.97), RK Puram (55.54) and Okhla (54.67), meaning a higher percentage of voters are facing exclusion.

Each voter was provided enumeration forms by the booth level officers (BLOs) during a house-to-house verification exercise between June 30 and August 17.

According to the constituency-wise data of digitised and uncollectable forms, only two constituencies Rohini (83.43 per cent) and Shakurbasti (81.26 per

cent) crossed the 80 per cent mark in digitised forms, meaning around 20 per cent voters in both will be excluded from the draft rolls.

There are 13 constituencies where around 40 to 50 per cent voters will be excluded from electoral rolls, while in 34 constituencies, nearly 30-40 per cent voters will miss the draft voter list.

Also, there are 21 constituencies which will see nearly 20-30 per cent exclusion of voters in the draft rolls.

The constituency-wise data presents a mixed pattern of percentage of voters whose forms were digitised and those who face exclusion. The pattern cuts across Delhi's economically affluent and backward areas, posh colonies as well as JJ clusters, unauthorised and resettlement colonies.

The voters under the absent and shifted category will be able to file their applications during the claims and objections phase starting from August 24.

Delhi Police overhauled in massive reshuffle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In one of the largest reshuffles of the Delhi Police force in recent times, the Delhi government has ordered the transfer and posting of 43 IPS and DANIPS officers with immediate effect. The Traffic Department emerged as one of the most heavily affected wings in the sweeping order.

The order, issued by the Home Department and signed by Principal Secretary (Home) Santosh D Vaidya, was approved by Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on the recommendation of the Police Establishment Board. It spans officers from the 1994 batch to the 2021 batch, along with two DANIPS officers, and includes several transfers of officers arriving from other states and union territories.

The scale of the exercise stands out, touching nearly every rank in the force, from Special Commissioners of Police down to Deputy Commissioners and Additional DCPs, cutting across districts, ranges and



specialised units.

The Traffic Department has seen a particularly high churn under the new order. At the top, Manish Agrawal, who headed Traffic as Special CP, has been moved to Special CP PSD, while Ajay Chaudhary, previously heading PSD, has taken over as Special CP Traffic in a direct swap between the two officers.

Further down the chain, Dinesh Kumar Gupta, who held the post of Additional CP Traffic, has been shifted to Additional CP DPHCL. In his place, Pratiksha Godara, who was serving as Additional CP DPHCL, has been moved to Additional CP Traffic at headquarters, mirroring the swap pattern seen at the

Special CP level.

At the DCP rank, Sachin Singhal, who was Additional DCP West District, has been elevated to DCP Traffic.

Separately, Shweta Chauhan, who was posted with the Anti-Corruption Branch, has also been moved to the post of DCP Traffic, indicating multiple postings within the Traffic Department at the DCP level as part of the same order. Taken together, the changes mean the Traffic Department has undergone leadership shifts at three separate levels, Special CP, Additional CP and DCP, all within a single reshuffle, underlining the scale of restructuring within this particular wing.

Beyond Traffic, the order carries significant changes across the force. Garima Bhatnagar continues as Special CP EOW while being given additional charge as MD of DPHCL. Atul Katiyar moves from Vigilance to Welfare and Legal Division.

Several officers have been brought in from other states, including Vivek Kishore from Arunachal Pradesh, who

takes charge as Special CP SPUWAC and Licensing, and Sindhu Pillai from Andaman and Nicobar Islands, who becomes Special CP Vigilance with additional charge of the Perception Management and Media Cell.

At the Joint CP level, Veenu Bansal moves to SPUWAC and SPUNER, Suman Goyal takes charge of the Western Range, and Jatinder Narwal shifts to Special Branch. Milind Mahadeo Dumbare has been posted to Eastern Range, with his transfer set to take effect from September 1, 2026, one of the few postings in the order with a deferred effective date.

Several DCP and Additional DCP postings involve officers arriving from outside Delhi. Manjeet joins from Chandigarh to head New Delhi District, while Geetanjali Khandelwal, also from Chandigarh, takes charge of Shahdara. Officers transferring in from Mizoram include Pukhraj Kamal Gupta, Lokeshwaran R and Gaurav Tyagi, posted to North District, Outer North District and IFSO respectively.



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



दिल्ली परिवहन निगम
राष्ट्रीय राजधानी क्षेत्र दिल्ली सरकार



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माननीय उपराज्यपाल, दिल्ली

श्रीमती रेखा गुप्ता
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री मनोज तिवारी
माननीय सांसद, उत्तर-पूर्वी दिल्ली

डॉ. पंकज कुमार सिंह
माननीय परिवहन मंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार

श्री सूर्य प्रकाश खत्री
माननीय विधायक, तिमारपुर

दिनांक: 19 अगस्त 2026 | समय: 11:00 AM
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IN FOCUS



An artisan paints an idol of Lord Krishna ahead of the Janmashtami festival in Amritsar on Tuesday

PTI

Delhi Congress slams purification ritual after Kharage rally

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Parliamentary Affairs Committee of the Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee (DPCC), led by president Devender Yadav, passed a resolution condemning what it called an insult to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge.

The resolution was passed after Hindu activists reportedly performed a “purification” ritual at Ramila Maidan in Haldwani, Uttarakhand, following a rally he addressed there. The resolution, moved by Yadav and seconded by SC Department chairman Rajendra Pal Gautam, was

mayor Farhad Suri. Yadav said the party had rebuilt itself at the grassroots over the past two years, crediting the Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan for earning Delhi Congress top ranking in AICC’s organisational review under general secretary KC Venugopal.

He alleged SIR was being used to eliminate over 45 lakh votes in Delhi, calling it a blot on democracy, and said Congress had deployed 13,031 BLA-2 workers compared to a poor AAP presence.

Maken praised the swift turnout of workers for protests over Rahul Gandhi and Kharage related issues,



unanimously approved. The meeting, held at Rajiv Bhawan, also discussed the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the upcoming Delhi University Students’ Union elections and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi elections.

Senior leaders present included AICC treasurer and MP Ajay Maken, AICC Delhi in-charge Qazi Nizamuddin, Mahila Congress president Alka Lamba, former MP Uditi Raj, Abhishek Dutt, Manish Chatrath, DPCC general secretary Anil Bhardwaj, former ministers Haroon Yusuf and Yogananda Shastri, former SC Department chairman Rajesh Lilothia and former

citing booth level vote data from the last election as evidence of Congress’s continuing base.

He said extending financial support to block presidents could help revive the party ahead of MCD polls and called for issues to be raised on the ground rather than through newspapers alone.

Nizamuddin criticised the BJP and RSS over the ritual incident, demanding an investigation and action against those responsible.

He said NSUI must strengthen its presence ahead of DUSU elections in September, calling the student polls significant for Delhi’s political direction.

Ayodhya row: SIT clears Champat Rai, Anil Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow/Ayodhya

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) that examined claims of irregularities in donations to the Ayodhya Ram Temple has cleared the Trust’s former general secretary, Champat Rai, in its first report, according to people familiar with the case. The Uttar Pradesh home department reviewed the findings and sent the report to the Trust for further action.

Sources said the final report does not mention Champat Rai or former trust member Anil Mishra. Both stepped down from the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on June 27 while the investigation was still underway.

The SIT was formed on June 13 by Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath following the Trust’s request for an inquiry. The three-member team included Lucknow Divisional Commissioner Vijay Vishwas Panth, Inspector General of Police



Kiran S and Special Secretary (Finance) Neel Ratan Kumar. They were assigned to look into complaints about donation handling and reports of theft. The SIT submitted its first report to the state government on June 23. Two days later, on June 25, Ayodhya police registered a case based on the findings. Sources said the full report found no reason to name Rai or Mishra in the alleged irregularities. With the home department now sending the report to the Trust, any next steps are up

to the temple body. Officials said the Trust will decide if any internal action is needed after reviewing the SIT’s findings. At the same time, a second Special Investigation Team, working under the Supreme Court’s supervision, is still looking into the same allegations.

The presence of two investigations shows how sensitive the issue of donation management is at this important religious site.

The Ram temple in Ayodhya was built after a long legal and political

process that ended with the 2019 Supreme Court verdict. Since its consecration, it has received large public donations.

Concerns about how these funds were managed led the Trust to ask for an official investigation earlier this year. People following the case said the first SIT’s decision to clear the two former officials does not end the larger inquiry.

The court-supervised second team will look into other aspects of donation collection, record-keeping, and the use of funds.

There is no public timeline for when the investigation will end. Rai and Mishra resigned from the Trust on June 27, a few days after the FIR was filed and while the Government was reviewing the initial findings.

People close to the situation said they stepped down to allow the investigation to continue without any appearance of conflict.

So far, neither has commented on the SIT report’s findings.

Social media, cash and terror: Inside Bhatti’s India network

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Shahzad Bhatti, a gangster from Pakistan, has an online following larger than that of many influencers. Around 2,50,000 people follow him on Instagram, and more than 4,50,000 follow him on Facebook. He posts in Punjabi, shows off luxury cars with Dubai license plates, displays weapons, and tries to look tough. Indian security agencies say his flashy online image was a way to attract people.

Right before Independence Day, police across several states busted the Bhatti’s network. This group, which is said to have support from Pakistan’s ISI, had been quietly recruiting young Indian men through the same social

media sites that made Bhatti famous.

On August 12, agencies detained 253 people in 14 States. More than 200 were arrested, and over 80 FIRs were filed under anti-terror and arms laws. Authorities found improvised explosive devices, grenades with Pakistan Ordnance Factory stamps, pistols, live bullets, and CCTV cameras aimed at police stations, defence sites and religious places. Investigators say some of the camera footage was meant to be sent live to handlers in another country.

Bhatti is thought to run his operations primarily from the UAE while maintaining ties to Pakistan. He does not fit the usual image of an underworld figure. Officials say he began as a gangster and later



became a terror handler. He went from organised crime and smuggling arms and drugs by drone along the Punjab border to planning low-cost, high-impact attacks in India. His network mixed criminal logistics with proxy warfare, paying local recruits in cash for jobs that ranged from easy to dangerous. The recruitment method

was simple. Bhatti and his team tracked who liked, commented on and interacted with his posts. They targeted vulnerable young men, often from low-income families, some dealing with drug problems or drawn to gangster culture. They contacted them through private messages or video calls. The first job paid between

₹5,000 and ₹10,000 to put up posters with Bhatti’s photo in public places. Police say these posters helped build his reputation and test loyalty.

After the first task was completed more serious jobs arrived. These included scouting crowded markets, hospitals, police stations, or areas near military sites; transporting smuggled weapons; setting up surveillance cameras; throwing grenades; and planting explosives. Investigators say that in some cases, recruits got online instructions for making petrol bombs and simple IEDs. Payments increased as the jobs became riskier, sometimes reaching lakhs for attacks on security personnel.

Bhatti’s online persona made the outlaw lifestyle seem appealing and helped

an intelligence agency recruit people who could be used and then discarded. Most recruits were not driven by ideology. They were either looking for opportunities or desperate for money, and were used for one or two jobs before being dropped.

The whole operation used encrypted apps, throwaway phone numbers, hawala money transfers, and secret drop-off points to keep the main leaders safe. Earlier, smaller police raids had already shown this pattern. In Delhi-NCR, groups including a biryani seller, a ginger vendor, and others were caught after being given jobs that ranged from putting up posters to planning attacks. Similar groups were found in Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Punjab, and other places.

Decide on Sainik Farm’s fate in 2 months: Delhi HC tells authorities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Noting that the issue of Sainik Farms regularisation is “pending for over a decade”, the Delhi High Court on Tuesday asked the officials of the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA), Delhi Government, Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to convene a meeting and address the issues related to Sainik Farm. Sainik Farm is an affluent but legally unauthorised and unregularised colony in South Delhi.

A Division Bench of Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia on Tuesday noted that the petitions related to

construction and legality of the colony have been pending before the court for over a decade and, therefore, ordered the Government authorities to conduct the exercise in two months.

The Bench underscored that it is high time that the authorities decide the issue of Sainik Farms.

“You have to take some decision. You cannot keep them in lurch. Something needs to be done. It’s your Government which has been bringing legislation after legislation for regularising. There are so many areas where you permit illegality, allow it to perpetuate and then regularise it. It is high time you should decide [Sainik Farm issue]. They should know their fate,” the Court said.



It added that at this stage, it was not permitting the residents to even repair the properties.

“At least we are not permitting

them to even undertake the repair. The construction is illegal, there is no layout there, there is no building plan,” the Bench remarked. The Bench made these observations while dealing with a batch of petitions related to the issue of Sainik Farm.

Additional Solicitor General (ASG) Chetan Sharma appeared for the Central Government and stated that in the past, whenever some humanitarian stand was taken and the residents of Sainik Farm were allowed to carry out some repair works, it brought about “catastrophic results and palaces came up in the area”.

“It is an island, my lords, which does not behave of who are living

there. And if I tell your lordships who are the beneficiaries, it might put all of us into embarrassment,” Sharma stated.

Sharma further stated that the DDA has come up with a master plan for the national Capital and the same is now pending with the Central Government.

In this South Delhi enclave, sprawling farmhouses, bungalows and luxury homes worth several crores stand amid tree-lined corridors, but basic services are absent. Everything from garbage collection and road maintenance to water supply is largely organised by residents themselves through their Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs).

SC orders probe into July 20 violence

The court further said that it would direct the handing over of video footage and CCTV recordings of the violence during the July 20 Parliament march in Delhi to the high-powered committee for examination.

The Bench asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to furnish details of FIRs implicating the student protesters, which are to be quashed, indicating that the SC may exercise its plenary powers under Article 142 of the Constitution.

“It is the life of students, which is at stake. We have to consider this. They have a future ahead. They have the right to protest under Article 19,” the Bench told a counsel who opposed quashing of cases against student protesters without them tendering an apology.

Nabin taps Tawde for UP, Poonia for Punjab...

The party failed to secure a majority on its own in the Lok Sabha for the first time since 2014. Uttar Pradesh has 80 Lok Sabha seats and 403 Assembly constituencies, making it a political heavy-weight and a key gateway to power in New Delhi. The party is now looking to regain lost ground before the 2027 Assembly contest.

UP Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Tuesday congratulated Tawde and Patel on being made the in-charge and co-in-charge, respectively, of party affairs in the State.

Interestingly, Poonia has been appointed as in-charge of Punjab, where the party did not have an in-charge following the death of former Gujarat CM Vijay Rupani in the Air India Flight 171 crash on June 12, 2025.

Poonia had earlier been appointed the BJP’s State in-charge for Haryana ahead of the Haryana Assembly elections. He has now been given charge of Punjab before its polls. The BJP has been trying to repair its political equations in Punjab since the farmers’ protests. Poonia’s appointment is therefore also being viewed as an attempt to address the discontent among farmers. Poonia has already been involved in efforts to strengthen the BJP’s Punjab unit and was seen as a key figure in the restructuring of the State organisation. Punjab has 117 Assembly seats, with elections likely to be held in February next year.

The appointments came a day after the party unveiled a new team of national office-bearers to assist Nabin. The party named 13 vice-presidents, including nine new faces; eight general secretaries, six of them first-time appointees, and 16 secretaries, 15 of whom are new.

Trump praises India’s polls as Congress takes...

Trump has been insisting on passing the Safeguard American Voter Eligibility (SAVE) America Act, claiming the move would curb electoral fraud.

Quick to react, the Congress party in India, which has raised allegations of voter deletions via the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls and irregularities in the preparation of voter rolls said, “Please take Gyanesh Kumar to America and keep him there.”

“We will send our EVMs too by the next available flight. For all the insults and bullying you’ve sent our way, this is the least we can do for you,” Congress leader, Pawan Khera posted on X.

On being asked asked about the US President’s comments, Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) spokesperson, Randhir Jaiswal said,

FROM PAGE - 1

“I have no specific comment to make on the remarks. I can say, however, that the credibility and robustness of India’s election machinery are well-established facts globally.”

Interestingly, voter participation in 2026 was nearly 94 per cent as compared to more than 40 per cent in 1951 when the first polls were held in independent India.

Polling in India is held based on a photo identity card. The ECI has issued a special Electoral Photo Identity Card (EPIC) to all close to a billion electors. Electoral rolls in India are prepared for each for the 1.2 million polling booths by the Booth Level Officers (BLOs) who are employees of the State government and are concurrently audited by the Booth Level Agents (BLAs) appointed by political parties.

Polling in Booths is also concurrently audited by Polling Agents appointed by the Candidates. Similarly, counting of votes is also concurrently audited by the Counting Agents appointed by the Candidates.

India tells Meta: Remove illegal CSAM or risk...

Ongoing talks are also looking at making algorithms more transparent, especially in how they decide what content to show or block.

Meta has shared some information about its systems, but the Government is still asking for more progress and real results. Sources acknowledge that moderation is complex, but the primary expectation is to comply with Indian law.

The issue of WhatsApp usernames is being handled separately. Sources said this is not just a problem with one platform, since similar issues appear with other messaging apps. The Government is looking at the wider digital communication system to find the right regulations.

They also pointed out that concerns about social media harms are not unique to India. Countries such as Australia, the United Kingdom, and France have also pressured major technology companies to improve safety. Platforms are expected to address online harms while still protecting users and allowing free expression.

On AI-generated content, the ministry repeated that Indian law requires synthetic material to be clearly labelled. Platforms and companies must make sure this labelling is done properly and consistently. In India, the law already says that AI-generated content must be clearly labelled, and platforms should be able to detect and share this information at every stage, from creation to sharing. Meanwhile, in a related issue, the Supreme Court asked the Centre, all states and Union Territories, and the social media platforms Meta and X to respond to a public-interest case. The case aims to stop police organisations from posting content that reveals the identities of accused people or shows them in a dehumanising way. Chief Justice of India, Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana heard arguments from senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, who represented petitioner Hemendra Patel. The court then sent notices to the Union Government, States, and social media platforms. The petition, filed by advocate Shrutanjaya Bhardwaj, asks for the immediate removal of police social media posts that show the faces or identities of accused people or portray them in a dehumanising way.

Police stand by use of force

It further claimed that the videos of police officials with lathis in plain clothes (spotters) show a crowd control measure out of context.

The affidavit stated that due to urgency of the situation, spotters from Special Branch, Special Cell, Crime Branch and Local Police strategically merged inside the crowd, which is neither illegal nor unusual. This tactic is in fact adopted in public gatherings on Independence Day, Republic Day, etc. as well.

The police said that the entire incident is comprehensively documented through intelligence inputs, deployment orders, crowd-management plans, Daily Diary entries, wireless log messages, CCTV footage, official videography, body-worn camera footage, medical records, damage assessment reports and other contemporaneous official documents. Numerous video recordings depicting protesters attacking police personnel and other security forces, damaging Government property and indulging in violence have already been collected and being preserved.

The affidavit noted that between July 20 and 26, the system identified 2,873 individuals whose facial matches corresponded with existing criminal records. Of these, 92 were allegedly involved in more than 10 criminal cases and 47 had been declared history-sheeters. The offences included serious crimes such as murder and rape, as well as violations under the POCSO and NDPS Acts. The police clarified that any investigation arising from the demonstrations would be limited to these 2,873 individuals and would not extend to those who were not flagged by the system.

According to the affidavit, a false narrative is being built to the effect that based upon the facial recognition system, biometrics of everyone and anyone is obtained, people are being called with their Aadhar cards, and the data is being sold to private entities. Such narrative is built not only falsely but clearly with some ulterior motives.



Representative image
WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

layers of conditioning, performance, protection and inherited stories,” she said.

The proposed programme has raised concerns among local groups about the kind of activities being promoted as yoga and wellness tourism in the area. Yoga practitioners and Hindu organisations said that the term “naked” had caused concern given the spiritual and religious associations of yoga in Uttarakhand.

“The hotel or the organisation has not taken permission to conduct this programme. We have asked the police to find out on whose permission it is being conducted. Along with this, the cyber cell has also been asked to investigate the social media post regarding this matter,” Almora district magistrate Anshul Singh said.

Search operations launched in J&K following terrorist sightings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

After a brief lull, suspected movement of terrorists has been recorded in some of the border areas of Jammu division in recent days, prompting the security forces to launch massive cordon and search operations in the general area to prevent any targeted strike.

The latest incident was reported from Talot village of Udhampur district, where at least two suspected terrorists knocked on the doors of a resident, asking for food late Monday night.

The alert residents immediately raised an alarm after the suspected terrorists fled the area without receiving



any food. Moving swiftly, a joint team of the security forces launched massive searches in the area to track down the footprints of suspected terrorists who were believed to have vanished in

the forested area of Khuban in the close vicinity.

During the day, coordinated searches were launched by the joint teams of the Jammu and Kashmir Police and the CRPF in Talot and

adjoining areas.

The security checkpoints were activated, and searches were conducted across vulnerable areas. Similar cordon and search operations were launched in the neighbouring districts.

According to official sources, security forces conducted searches in the Sadini forest area of Reasi and in several border villages in Kathua's Hiranagar sector near the International Border, where suspicious movement was reported in the last 24 hours.

Officials said the operations are part of heightened vigilance amid recent inputs regarding infiltrators and suspicious movement in the region.

NGT allows fresh petition over illegal mining on forest land in Lahaul-Spiti, Kullu districts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has allowed filing of a fresh petition over the alleged illegal mining in Lahaul-Spiti and Kullu districts.

The NGT bench comprising Justice Arun Kumar Tyagi and expert member Senthil Vel, in the order passed on August 10, allowed applicant Abhishek Rai to withdraw his earlier complaint after he appeared in person for a hearing in Delhi. The order was made available on Tuesday.

Rai had filed a petition on May 12 by post, after which the tribunal treated it suo motu and registered it as an Original Application(OA).

The complaint raised grievances regarding illegal



mining and the installation of stone crushers on forest lands in Dhundi, Manali, Buruwa in Kullu district, and Keling Sarai, Chika Palmo, Khoksar, Gue, Zing Zing Bara-Lahaul and Roli in Lahaul and Spiti.

Rai in his plea alleged that Garg and Garg Construction Company, and Vinita

Construction Company, operating in the twin districts, deployed stone crushers on forest land without obtaining mandatory permissions and

clearances from the competent authorities, including the Forest and Mining Department and Himachal Pollution Control Board.

He further claimed that

these companies are illegally extracting and supplying construction material to the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) on a large scale.

The complaint also alleged that they are violating mining laws, environmental norms and forest conservation regulations, asserting that these illegal activities are damaging forest land and the fragile Himalayan ecology, causing environmental degradation, pollution and loss of revenue to the state Government.

The petition further stated that in a scheduled/tribal district, a non-tribal person is legally prohibited from operating a stone crusher and that mining is prohibited within 100 metres from khuds (drains).

British-era silver coins unearthed in MP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Old silver coins believed to date back to the British era have been discovered during excavation work for a Greenfield Highway near Dongarpur Lodha village in Madhya Pradesh's Morena district.

Official sources said some villagers found the coins while excavation work was underway around 5 pm on Monday. A JCB operator involved in the excavation is also reported to have found coins at the site. The matter came to the administration's notice on Tuesday after a video showing the coins surfaced.

The administration has begun an inquiry into the discovery and directed the police to collect and secure the coins. Officials are also trying to determine the exact number of coins recovered and the precise location from which they were unearthed.

The coins recovered so far bear the inscription 'GEORGE V KING EMPEROR' along with the year 1913. The reverse side carries the words "ONE



RUPEE INDIA". Based on the inscriptions, officials have indicated that the coins appear to belong to the British period. Their exact historical significance and other details will be established after examination by the concerned department.

District archaeology officer Ashok Sharma said one of the recovered coins weighs around 11.6 grams and is understood to contain about 91% silver. He said the coin carries the year 1913 and the inscription "One Rupee India". Officials are gathering information about how many coins were found by villagers and the JCB operator. Additional District Magistrate Ashwani Rawat said the administration had received information about

the discovery of old silver coins during excavation for the Greenfield Highway. Police have been instructed to investigate the matter and collect the coins. Once the initial investigation is complete, the recovered coins will be handed over to the Archaeology Department.

The discovery has drawn attention because the coins resemble the one-rupee silver coins issued during the reign of King George V between 1911 and 1936.

Such coins typically weighed around 11.66 grams and contained approximately 91.7 per cent silver. Their value to collectors can vary significantly depending on factors such as condition, rarity, mint mark and authenticity.

Wildlife SOS denies ties to arrested wildlife traders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With a track record of 32 years of wildlife conservation in 19 States and credited with rescuing over 5,31,000 animals in coordination with the forest departments, Wildlife SOS has refuted allegations of wildlife crime.

Kartick Satyanarayan, CEO and co-founder of the NGO, said in a statement on Monday, "This is shocking, and we are deeply con-



cerned. Our immensely celebrated efforts over the years in rescuing and eventual

banning of dancing bears in India are just one of the many stories that

we are proud of.

"As torchbearers of India's wildlife and forest resources, we protect, we preserve, and we plan for the health and the welfare of creatures who are voiceless." Wildlife SOS also highlighted that allegations had been "flung with absolutely no basis", and it was "completely" cooperating and willing for any kind of investigation.

Treating legitimate anti-poaching intelligence work as wildlife crime could have a

chilling effect on future wildlife enforcement, he added.

The rebuttal came following reports linking it with a wildlife-contraband trader and his associate, arrested by the Madhya Pradesh State Tiger Strike Force (STSF) earlier this week.

Reports said accused Bhagwan Singh alias Salim and his accomplice Wasim were on the payroll of a prominent Delhi-based wildlife conservation organisation.

West Bengal Police rejects claims of brutal assault of CJP worker' father

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Bengal Police have rejected claims of brutal assault on Janab Malik, the father of SK Abdul, a CJP volunteer from Bankura district who allegedly died two days ago from injuries suffered during an attack by alleged BJP workers. The police claimed that, hours after the CJP leadership threatened an intensified stir should the government not take stringent action against the perpetrators of the crime.

The police acknowledged that there was a brawl but said that Janab Mafik sustained a "minor injury" requiring a single stitch. The police said that the alleged 'victim' "got self-admitted to Burdwan Medical College after experiencing severe blood pressure fluctuations" on Monday morning, adding "no life-threatening injury was found by doctors who treated him."

The statement also iterated that "baseless and false claims began circulating online alleging that Mafik (Janab Malik) had died from a 'brutal physical assault.'" The



Deceased's son Sheikh Abdul Hafiz with his mother

police statement came almost in tandem with an ultimatum issued by CJP national leader Ashutosh Ranka, who, along with a team, visited the house of the 'victim' before issuing a warning that massive movement would be started if all the ten perpetrators of the alleged offence were not prosecuted. The police had arrested eight out of the ten accused named in the FIR, sources said.

Abdul had earlier complained that he had gone to the local Karisunda Paschimpara Primary School to inspect for himself the infrastructural facilities there following a "school theek karo (repair the schools)" programme launched by the national CJP leadership.

After returning from the school, "threats started coming to me and then came the attack... they came to my house and attacked me... as my father tried to save me, he was brutally assaulted... later he died in the hospital."

"We have been told that the local BJP MLA and his cronies are terrorising the people... they have attacked and killed the father of our volunteer here who just wanted to improve the facilities of the school that he read in... if this is not stopped and if the accused are not arrested then a sustained movement will ensue," Ranka said.

Jaishankar, Sitharaman, Goyal to travel to Singapore for crucial talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Singapore will look to further expand their cooperation in several key sectors such as trade, investment, advanced manufacturing and digitisation during a meeting of their top ministers on Thursday.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and Minister of State for Electronics and Information Technology Jitin Prasada will travel to Singapore for the fourth India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR), according to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). During their visit, the ministers will interact with their counterparts and will also call on the Singaporean leadership, it said on Tuesday. "The mechanism of ISMR is an important plat-



form to drive cooperation including in new and emerging areas," it said.

Inaugural meeting of ISMR was held in New Delhi in September 2022, followed by the second meeting in Singapore in August 2024. The third ISMR meeting was held in New Delhi in August last year. "Deliberations on advanced manufacturing, connectivity, digitalisation, healthcare and medicine, skills Development, and sustainability, from these meetings drive the roadmap for India-Singapore Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP Roadmap)," MEA said.





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Governor, Yamanashi Prefecture, Japan



19th August, 2026
09:00 AM onwards



TAJ PALACE,
New Delhi

GROUND BREAKING CEREMONY OF



Sector-10, YEIDA

Investment: ₹2,029 Crore
Employment Proposed: 3,800+
Production Proposed Annually
Tractor: ~60,000 Units
Construction Equipment
Plant: ~15,000 Units



Sector-10 & 24, YEIDA

Investment: ₹1,166 Crore
Employment Proposed: 6,440+
Production Proposed Annually
Electronic Switch, Sensor, USB chargers
for Two & Four Wheelers: 20 Lakh Units

SECTOR-FOCUSED ROUNDTABLES

Automotive, Data Centres, Semiconductors, Electronics, IT/ITES, Green Hydrogen, Chemicals, Food Processing, etc.

High-Level Dialogue with Japanese CXOs & Business Leaders

In the august presence of

Shivraj Singh Chouhan
Minister, Agriculture & Farmers Welfare and Rural Development, Government of India

Suresh Kumar Khanna
Minister, Finance & Parliamentary Affairs, Uttar Pradesh

Sunil Kumar Sharma
Minister, Electronics & Information Technology, Uttar Pradesh

Yogi Adityanath
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

Arvind Kumar Sharma
Minister, Urban Development, Overall Urban Development, Urban Employment and Poverty Alleviation, Energy, Additional Sources of Energy, Uttar Pradesh

Jaswant Singh Saini
Minister of State, Parliamentary Affairs, Industrial Development, Uttar Pradesh

Ashwini Vaishnaw
Minister, Railways, Information & Broadcasting, Electronics & Information Technology, Government of India

Nand Gopal Gupta 'Nandi'
Minister, Industrial Development, Export Promotion, NRI & Investment Promotion, Uttar Pradesh

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States Focus



VP TO ADDRESS IAS AND IFS PROBATIONERS IN UTTARAKHAND

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan will visit Uttarakhand on Wednesday and Thursday, where he will address Indian Administrative Service and Indian Forest Service probationers. On Wednesday, the vice president will visit the Indira Gandhi National Forest Academy (IGNFA) in Dehradun, where he will address and interact with Indian Forest Service (IFS) probationers of the 2025-27 batch, an official statement said. On Thursday, he will be the chief guest at the valedictory ceremony of Phase-II of the IAS Professional Course for the 2024 batch at the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA) in Mussoorie, it said. (PTI)



BIHAR: LALU CALLS FOR MARCH TO LOK BHAVAN ON AUGUST 19

RJD supremo Lalu Prasad on Tuesday called for a march to the Lok Bhavan on August 19 against the "dictatorial attitude" of the State Government that "responds to democratic demands with bullets from an AK-47".

The opposition party's leader said members of the Mahagathbandhan alliance would attend the march and submit a memorandum to the governor over the alleged firing of an AK-47 rifle against student protesters in Siwan district last month.

A police constable was suspended after a video purportedly showing him using an AK-47 rifle during a student protest in Bihar's Siwan district on July 25 against an NEET exam paper leak went viral on social media. (PTI)

Odisha CM announces ₹1,000-crore flood package

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Tuesday announced a ₹1,000 crore relief package for areas affected by floods and free kitchens for people evacuated from inundated areas till the situation improves.

As the State experienced two bouts of flooding within one month, the chief minister attributed it to "1,100 mm of rain since June" despite the forecast of scant rainfall due to the El Nino weather pattern.

"This amount of rainfall is the highest in Odisha over a period of 25 years," the chief minister said, adding the state has been successfully tackling the situation.

Addressing a press conference, he said, "Based on the IMD's El Nino warning, all of us were expecting scant rainfall in the state. Therefore, the reservoirs were directed to store water in case there was less rain during the monsoon."

"However, the state received around 1100 mm of rainfall since the beginning of the monsoon in June. This is 34 per cent over normal in the State."

Majhi also reviewed the flood situation in the six districts of Balasore, Bhadrak, Jajpur, Mayurbhanj, Keonjhar and Kendrapara.

Stating that the second spell of flooding has so far impacted nearly 9.40 lakh people in six districts, Majhi said maintaining zero casu-



Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi

PTI

alties was the priority of his Government.

"Although around 100 people were bitten by snakes in the flood-affected areas, all of them survived because of easy availability of anti-

venom injections," the chief minister said.

While at least six people were killed in the first spell of floods, the Government was yet to confirm the toll this time.

Manipur MLA delegation to visit Delhi to apprise central leaders on NRC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

The Manipur Government on Tuesday reiterated its stand that the National Register of Citizens (NRC) updation should be taken up in the State and that a delegation of MLAs will be visiting New Delhi to apprise the central leaders of the issue.

Manipur Government spokesperson and MLA Dr Sapam Ranjan Singh told reporters that "The Government has been very, very serious on the issues pertaining to NRC and the census and concerns related to demographic imbalances and changes. The concerns of the people are also ours."

Singh said, "Manipur Legislative Assembly had passed a resolution on August 5, 2022, urging that the NRC be taken up in the State. The resolution was subsequently reaf-



firmed by the Assembly on March 1, 2024. This has been a long-standing issue of utmost concern for our Government. The Government has been corresponding with the Union Home Ministry."

He also said that a team of MLAs would visit New Delhi to seek guidance and urge the Central Government to take up the NRC updation.

Singh said, "We have been pushing for NRC right from before and have been contin-

cerns the future of the State and its people.

Singh also reiterated that the State Government acknowledges the demand of civil society organisations and the people of Manipur that NRC should be conducted before the Census.

On the ongoing bandh and protests, Singh said that peaceful protest is a democratic right and appealed to the protesters to express their grievances peacefully and democratically without resorting to violence or causing inconvenience to the general public, students and people whose livelihoods may be affected by the disruptions.

Regarding the NRC process, he stated that the matter requires discussion and consideration at various levels and that several aspects may need to be addressed before the NRC can be taken up.

Marandi slams Jharkhand Govt on exam scrapping

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

Jharkhand's Leader of Opposition Babul Marandi on Tuesday alleged that the JMM-led Government is "cheating agitating students" by announcing the cancellation of recruitment exams and demanded a probe by the CBI.

The BJP leader said that reports are emerging about irregularities in both the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC), and alleged that jobs were sold by both agencies, compromising the rights of the State's students and aspirants.

The Jharkhand Government on Monday announced the cancellation of the JSSC-CGL exam and all recruitment tests conducted by outsourced agency TDPL since 2014.



"The Hemant Soren Government is cheating the students by announcing the cancellation of the examination. When the Government knows that the agitators want an investigation by the CBI, why is it then backing out? It is clear from this that the people sitting in the Government are also involved in selling jobs," said Marandi, a former chief minister.

The BJP has maintained a clear position from the very beginning that the CBI should investigate the entire matter, since evidence is gradually appearing that both agencies sold jobs, he claimed.

JD(S) protests agricultural land acquisition for Bidadi township

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The JD(S) on Tuesday staged a massive protest in Bengaluru against the acquisition of agricultural land for the proposed GBIT project near Bidadi in Karnataka.

The protest held at Freedom Park here was led by former Prime Minister and party supremo HD Deve Gowda.

A huge number of farmers from various districts of the State, along with members of JDS and BJP, participated in the protest.

Speaking to reporters, Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy extended his support to farmers protesting against the acquisition of agricultural land for the proposed project, alleging that the State Government had ignored the demands of farmers who have been protesting for nearly 500 days.

Kumaraswamy said the farming community had been continuously opposing the Government's move to acquire their land and alleged

that the Government was acting "arrogantly" by refusing to heed their requests.

"For the last 500 days, this Government has arrogantly not given any response to the requests of the farming community. This Government is going against the farmers' demands," he said.

Kumaraswamy claimed that more than 80 per cent of the farming community in the affected area was not willing to surrender their ancestral properties for the proposed project.

"This massive protest rally is not... to misuse the farming community to strengthen our party. The farming community is requesting the Government not to take their land in the name of an integrated city or township," he said.

He said his party had always supported farmers whenever they faced difficulties or when Governments made decisions against their interests, and that today's massive rally has been held to oppose the Government's decision and stand with the voice of the farming community.



Former prime minister HD Deve Gowda, front centre, with Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy, front left, and JD(S) Youth Wing leader Nikhil Kumaraswamy, second right, during a protest against the acquisition of farmers' land for the Bidadi township project at Freedom Park in Bengaluru on Tuesday

PTI

JD(S) youth wing president Nikhil Kumaraswamy alleged that the Congress Government was trying to forcibly acquire farmers' land in the name of development and was using the project to make money through real estate.

He said a march from Byramangala near Bidadi to Freedom Park had been stopped by the Government after two days of the *padayatra*.

"Two days of *padayatra* made such an impact that the

Government was shaken up, and they completely stopped us," he told reporters.

On August 9, the JD(S) had organised a *padayatra* against the acquisition of agricultural land for the proposed GBIT project.

Supported by alliance partner BJP, the march from Byramangala near Bidadi to Freedom Park in Bengaluru city, led by Nikhil, was originally planned for three days but it called off the march on its second day (August 10) after police stopped them

near Kaniminike.

Today we are standing for farmers, so the Government at least now should step up their game and should make sure that they do not forcefully do the project," he said.

Accusing the Congress Government of using development as a pretext for financial gains, he said, "Today the Congress, in the name of development, want to loot." "This project is only to make money out of real estate," he alleged.

Amid protests by farmers and locals, the Government has constituted a high-level committee headed by retired High Court Judge Justice Guhanathan Narendar to review the varying opinions and feedback regarding the Greater Bengaluru Integrated Township project.

Earlier, despite opposition from farmers and local people, the Government has issued two sets of final notifications for the acquisition of over 5,400 acres of land spread across seven villages for the GBIT project, which is projected as India's "first AI-powered integrated township".

Karnataka global hub for new research: CM Shivakumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Tuesday said that the State has emerged as a global hub for new research because of the skills of its youth, and stressed that skill was an asset that no one can steal.

Addressing World Youth Skills Day at the Banquet Hall of Vidhana Soudha, Shivakumar said education must be accompanied by skill if the country was to progress.

"Skill means the confluence of intellectuals and achievers. No one can steal skill. Thanks to the skills of the youth here. Karnataka has become the hub of new research in the world," he said.

"If the country needs to become more aware, skill must accompany education. Possessing a skill is like enjoying a royal fortune (*Rajayoga*); no one can steal it," he said, noting that



California had 1.3 million IT engineers while Bengaluru alone had 2.5 million IT professionals.

Every person possessed some skill, he said, citing goldsmiths, carpenters and even prisoners who helped construct Vidhana Soudha before modern technology became available.

Shivakumar said industrialists such as those heading the Tata and Mahindra conglomerates had studied and acquired skills in Bengaluru before expanding their businesses globally. "Do not restrict your competition to Belagavi, Hubballi, or

Dharwad — you must compete at the global level," he told students.

Recalling the history of IISC, he said Swami Vivekananda had discussed India's poverty with Jamsetji Tata during a ship journey and concluded that poverty could be eradicated through science. Vivekananda subsequently approached the then Maharaja of Mysore, leading to the establishment of IISc on 360 acres, he said, adding that the institution had since produced hundreds of thousands of talented scientists.

"No one can steal skill. My power and office might end one day, but the skill within me will not. Furthermore, the education we acquire never fades away," he said.

Shivakumar said degrees did not necessarily translate into skill or common sense, pointing to farmers ploughing fields in straight lines and women planting crops precisely without being taught by engineers or using rulers.

Andhra Govt committed to developing State's coastline: Minister Janardhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Infrastructure Minister BC Janardhan Reddy on Tuesday said the TDP-led Government is committed to developing the State's coastline and promised to complete all port and fishing harbour projects soon.

Addressing the Assembly, the Infrastructure Minister said the Government will expedite Budagatlalalem fishing harbour works in Srikakulam district, and construct a Fish Landing Centre (FLC) in Manchinillapeta.

"Under the leadership of CM Chandrababu Naidu, the coalition Government is committed to the development of the coastline. Very soon we will complete all the port and fishing harbour projects taken up in the State," he said.

Acknowledging existing



infrastructural and cold storage issues at Krishnapatnam and Ramayyapatnam ports, the minister promised to resolve them soon.

According to Reddy, the Adani Krishnapatnam Port management has agreed to offer ₹25 crore Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) funds for Nelaturu FLC.

Already, he said, ₹15 crore worth of development works are underway, promising to resolve

pending issues to avoid hassles for fishermen. In West Godavari district, Reddy said the fishing harbour at Biyyaputippa village will be converted into an FLC, among other initiatives.

Addressing the issues being faced by coconut farmers in Konaseema region, Agriculture Minister K Atchannaaidu said the Government has devised an action plan for a permanent solution rather than a temporary fix.

Excessive judicial interventions slow down arbitration decision: Panel

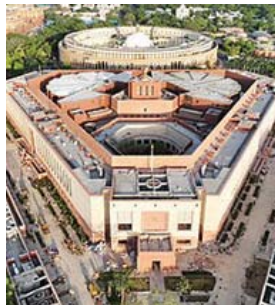
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid the Government's push to make India an international arbitration hub, a parliamentary committee has lamented that "excessive or inconsistent" judicial intervention affects the efficiency of arbitration.

It said such interventions often slow down what is intended to be a quicker alternative to court litigation.

"While some level of court oversight is necessary to ensure fairness and legality, frequent or avoidable intervention can lead to inordinate delays and may also dilute the independence of the arbitral process," the committee said.

In its latest report on institutional alternative dispute resolution submitted in Parliament last week,



the department-related standing committee on law and personnel has also flagged "limited global visibility" as a challenge for the country's alternative dispute resolution ecosystem and has suggested consistent quality in arbitral proceedings as one of the solutions.

The panel noted that the evolving nature and increasing complexity of disputes today require regular assessment of the

capacity of alternative dispute resolution institutions as demands continue to grow over time.

"In many instances, existing wherewithal does not keep pace with this rising demand, which can affect both the quality and speed of dispute resolution," it pointed out.

There is a need, it said, for continuous evaluation and timely upgradation of resources, systems, and professional capabilities to ensure that these institutions remain efficient, responsive, and well-equipped to handle disputes effectively.

"The Committee, therefore, recommends that ADR institutions put in place regular review mechanisms to assess their functioning and identify the gaps in infrastructure, staffing, and expertise."

Awareness on Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyan launched by Saharsa DIG



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

As part of the Government's Nasha Mukh Bharat Abhiyan (Drug-Free India Campaign), an awareness program was held at Middle School, Rahumani in Saharsa district. The event was graced by Dr Kumar Ashish, Deputy Inspector General of Police (DIG), Koshi Range, Saharsa, who addressed the gathering of students, parents, and educators.

He highlighted the severe physical, psychological, and social risks of substance abuse and urged the youth to stay drug-free. The session concluded with participants taking a formal pledge against drug consumption. On the occasion, the DIG also launched a dedicated anti-drug helpline number (9060384865) for reporting illicit trafficking or consumption via call, SMS, or WhatsApp.

Govt unveils indigenisation list of 405 strategically important items

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Stepping up its efforts to achieve self-reliance in defence production, the Government on Tuesday released the sixth Positive Indigenisation List (PIL) of 405 strategically important items with an estimated business potential of ₹3, 070 crore.

The Department of Defence Production (DDP), Ministry of Defence, has notified the sixth Positive Indigenisation List (PIL).

It contains Line Replaceable Units, sub-systems, sub-assemblies, spares, components and raw materials. These include 16 items of the Indian Coast Guard (ICG) and 389 items of Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs). The items cover a broad range of defence platforms and systems, including Air platforms such as Advanced Light Helicopter, Light Utility Helicopter, Su-30MKI, Light Combat Aircraft and AL-31FP engine, and Armoured platforms including T-72, T-90 and BMP-II Warships.



The other items are Missile systems such as Konkurs-M, Invar and MRSAM; defence electronics including radars, sonars, fire control systems and satellite communication systems; high-explosive anti-tank ammunition and other critical defence equipment.

The detailed list of items is available on the SRIJAN Portal (srijandefence.gov.in). Each item has an indicative timeline for indigenisation. Upon successful indigenous development, these items will be procured from the

Indian industry. The DPSUs and ICG will undertake indigenisation through various routes, including their 'Make' procedure and in-house development, with participation from the industry, particularly MSMEs.

This sixth PIL marks another step in the government's efforts to promote self-reliance in defence manufacturing under the Aatmanirbhar Bharat initiative. It is expected to further expand opportunities for the Indian industry, strengthen

the domestic defence manufacturing ecosystem, promote investment and innovation, and contribute to reducing dependence on imports.

The DDP launched the SRIJAN Defence Portal in August 2020 as a dedicated platform through which the DPSUs and Service Headquarters (SHQs) offer defence items to the industry, including MSMEs and start-ups, for indigenous development and production.

Since its launch, the portal has facilitated the offer of more than 33,000 defence items for indigenisation by DPSUs and SHQs up to June 2026. These include 5,012 items notified under the first five Positive Indigenisation Lists.

More than 15,700 defence items have been successfully indigenised, resulting in an estimated import substitution value of about Rs 9,000 crore over the last five years. In addition, DPSUs have placed procurement orders, including in-house production, worth approximately Rs 10,000 crore with domestic vendors up to March 2026.

8 killed, 32 injured in MP highway crash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhind

Eight labourers were killed and 32 others injured when the pickup vehicle carrying them collided head-on with a dumper truck in Madhya Pradesh's Bhind district early Tuesday, police said.

The accident took place around 1 am near Chhimka village on the Bhind-Gwalior National Highway. The labourers, who were residents of Uttar Pradesh's Lakhimpur Kheri district, were returning home after completing paddy transplantation work in Gwalior.

According to preliminary findings, the pickup driver tried to avoid cattle sitting on the highway and lost control of the vehicle.

The pickup then moved onto the wrong side of the road and crashed into the oncoming dumper, said Ramnaresh Yadav, in-charge of Gohad Chauraha police station.

The collision was so severe that the pickup was badly damaged and several labourers became trapped inside. Five labourers died at the spot, while three others succumbed to their injuries while being taken to hospital.



Police teams reached the site after receiving information about the accident. With assistance from local residents, they pulled the trapped labourers out of the mangled vehicle.

All the injured were initially taken to a hospital in Gohad, where they received first aid. Those with serious injuries were later referred to Gwalior for specialised treat-

ment. Kheri Superintendent of Police Khyati Garg confirmed the eight deaths and expressed condolences to the families of the victims.

Six of the deceased have been identified as Updesh, Amar Singh, Sukhdev and Rajneesh, all residents of Bela Tursiya village in the Mohammadi area and aged between 30 and 45 years. The other two identi-

fied victims were Subhash, 30, from Harna Neoli village and Guddu, 45, from Kishanpur Ajit village in the Pasgawan area.

The identities of two other victims were yet to be established. Mohammadi police station SHO Umesh Chaurasiya said relatives of some of the deceased and injured had reached the accident site.

Coast Guard rescue 9 fishermen from sinking boat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Daman

An Indian Coast Guard (ICG) team from Daman on Tuesday rescued nine fishermen, three of them injured, from a boat that was reported to be sinking in the Arabian Sea.

The team from the ICG Air Station (ICGAS) swiftly responded to a distress call and launched a rescue operation with the help of a helicopter, an official release said.

"The Indian Coast Guard Air Station Daman swiftly responded to a distress call regarding an Indian fishing boat carrying nine fishermen.

The boat was reported to be sinking, posing an imminent threat to the lives of all nine fishermen," the release stated. After receiving the call, ICGAS immediately dis-



patched a Chetak helicopter to the reported position of the boat and safely rescued nine fishermen, it said.

"During the rescue operation, it was observed that three fishermen had sustained minor injuries.

The injured fishermen were brought to the ICGAS Daman, where they received first aid.

Subsequently, they were shifted to a Government Hospital for further medical treatment," the release noted.

The swift and coordinated response by the ICG averted a potential accident and reaffirmed the maritime law enforcement agency's unwavering commitment to saving lives at sea and ensuring the safety of fishermen and mariners, it added.

IIT Bombay launches e-PG diploma in computer science, AI



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

IIT Bombay's Educational Outreach is offering an e-Postgraduate Diploma in Computer Science and Artificial Intelligence (CS and AI) in line with the growing role of AI in modern computing.

The programme is aimed at software developers, engineers, IT professionals and data scientists who have learnt computer science either during their undergraduate studies with basic computer science knowledge, IIT Bombay said.

Designed and delivered by IIT Bombay faculty, with Great Learning as the EdTech partner, the programme combines strong computer science foundations with contemporary developments in AI and Machine Learning.

Drugs worth over ₹10 cr seized, 7 traffickers held in Assam

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Drugs worth more than ₹10 crore were seized and seven suspected drug traffickers arrested from different parts of Assam.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, in a social media post on Tuesday, said that 50,000 Yaba tablets worth Rs 10 crore were seized from a truck's secret chamber at Old MVI checkpoint in Digharkhal area of Cachar district.

"Humpty Dumpty had a great fall. So did this drug haul. Good job @cacharpolice and @assampolice," he said. During the operation, one suspected drug trafficker was



Assam Police seize huge drug trafficking haul in Cachar PIONEER PHOTO

also arrested, he added. The chief minister's office, in a post on social media, said that 234.89 kg of ganja were seized from Bhairabkunda in Udalguri district and six people apprehended.

"Legal action is underway against those apprehended in both operations," it added.

Sarma applauded Assam Police for the decisive action and stressed that the state's fight against the drug menace will continue with full force. Yaba or 'crazy medicine' in Thai is a tablet form of a mixture of methamphetamine (a powerful and addictive stimulant) and caffeine.

Drivers to get time to learn Marathi before action: Sarnaik

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Autorickshaw and taxi drivers will get an opportunity to learn Marathi before action is initiated against them for failing to comply with the language requirement, Maharashtra Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik said on Tuesday amid concerns among some sections over the rule enforcement.

The amended motor vehicle rules have evoked mixed reactions, with some supporting the need to know the local language, and others opposing them.

Union minister Ramdas Athawale has argued against



Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik

immediate action, saying it could create disputes and affect the livelihoods of drivers from other

states. Indicating a softening of the stand, Sarnaik said the Government would not immediately cancel permits or licenses of drivers who do not know Marathi.

He emphasised that the aim was not to deprive them of their livelihood but to ensure those providing passenger transport services in Maharashtra possess a working knowledge of the language.

Nearly six lakh auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers operating in Maharashtra, Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), will be brought under a Marathi-language learning initiative, he said at a press conference here.

"There are around 9.16 lakh auto-rickshaws and 61,657 taxis in Maharashtra. A large number of them operate in the MMR. We have decided to continue the initiative and make efforts to teach Marathi to those who do not know the language," Sarnaik said.

According to a notification issued by the state transport department, licences and permits of drivers of passenger vehicles could be suspended and eventually cancelled if they fail to acquire the required knowledge of Marathi within the stipulated period.

Under the amended rules, if a driver is found lacking the required

knowledge, the licensing authority will issue a notice granting him one month to acquire it.

If the driver fails to comply within that period, the authority may suspend the authorisation on his driving licence for three months. In case of continued non-compliance, the authority may revoke the authorisation.

A large number of passenger vehicle drivers across Maharashtra hail from other states.

Some drivers and union leaders have expressed concern that cancellation of licences and permits could adversely affect their livelihood.

Meghalaya CM announces ₹2 lakh ex gratia for kin of hotel fire victims



Conrad K Sangma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shillong

Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma on Tuesday announced an ex-gratia of Rs 2 lakh each for the next of kin of five people from the state who died in a hotel fire in West Bengal's Birbhum district, and assured medical support to six injured survivors.

Expressing condolences to the bereaved families, the chief minister said the state Government had decided to provide the financial assistance as immediate support following the tragedy.

"Yesterday we received the tragic news of the fire that broke out at a hotel in Tarapith in Birbhum district in West Bengal where five people from our state of Meghalaya lost their lives," he said.

AIIMS Delhi, Indian Stroke Association hold CME to boost stroke care in India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 400 healthcare professionals participated in a continuing medical education (CME) programme organised by the Department of Neurology, AIIMS Delhi, in collaboration with the Indian Stroke Association (ISA) to discuss strategies for expanding stroke care in India from prevention and early recognition to advanced treatment.

The CME, titled "Save the Brain — Stroke is Preventable and Treatable", was held on August 6, marking the centenary of cerebral angiography and paying tribute to its



pioneer, Egas Moniz.

The programme focused on strengthening stroke prevention, timely diagnosis,

referral mechanisms, acute treatment, rehabilitation and community awareness.

AIIMS, Delhi, Director Dr

Nikhil Tandon, who was the chief guest, highlighted the evolution of stroke medicine from recognising neurological deficits to preserving brain function and said stroke care was a collective responsibility.

"We should aspire to learn neurology from preserved brain function, not from the loss of brain function caused by stroke," Dr Tandon said.

Additional Secretary and Mission Director (NHM), Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Aradhana Patnaik, emphasised prevention, early recognition, timely referral and coordinated care through National Health

Mission initiatives, including Ayushman Arogya Mandirs. She highlighted the need for screening for stroke risk factors and structured training of ASHAs, ANMs, community health officers and medical officers, besides strengthening referral pathways through hub-and-spoke models. "Policy at every level should ensure good quality treatment while placing greater emphasis on prevention," Patnaik said.

NIITI Aayog member Dr M Srinivas stressed the need for a holistic continuum of care covering prevention, early recognition, acute treatment, rehabilitation

and community awareness. He highlighted the brain-health initiative being undertaken in 12 aspirational districts and called for greater multidisciplinary collaboration in stroke care. He also suggested that school students could become effective ambassadors for stroke awareness in communities.

Dr Shailesh B Gaikwad, Chief, Neurosciences Centre and Head of the Department of Neuroimaging and Interventional Neuroradiology at AIIMS, shared his expertise in neurovascular interventions and called for expansion of stroke intervention ser-

vices across the country.

He also advocated greater promotion of Make-in-India neurovascular devices to strengthen access to advanced stroke treatment.

Dr Awadh Kishor Pandit, who was associated with the CME, said the programme underlined the need to move beyond hospital-based treatment and build a comprehensive stroke-care ecosystem.

"Stroke is not only a neurological emergency, but it is also a public health challenge that requires prevention, rapid recognition, timely referral and access to advanced treatment.

Editor's

TAKE

The courage that refuses to look away

World Humanitarian Day honours the selfless service of humanitarian workers. But they need protection and funding, not just applause

On August 19, 2003, a truck bomb tore through the Canal Hotel in Baghdad, the UN's headquarters in Iraq, killing 22 people, including the gifted diplomat Sergio Vieira de Mello. Five years later, the UN General Assembly turned that tragedy into an annual reminder: humanitarian work is not safe, comfortable, or thankless in the abstract - it is dangerous, specific, and carried out by people with names and families. That is why World Humanitarian Day matters.

In a world numbed by the scale of suffering – Gaza, Sudan, Ukraine, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and the slow-moving disasters of climate change – humanitarian workers are the ones who still walk towards the wreckage rather than walk away from it. They are proof that decency has not been argued out of existence. In an age of cynicism about institutions, the aid worker distributing vaccines in a flooded village or negotiating a ceasefire corridor for food trucks offers something rarer than optimism: evidence.

This year's UN campaign, #ActForHumanity, captures that plainly - humanity is not a slogan; it is a practice, renewed daily by people who choose it under fire. Yet the record now being set is not one to celebrate. The UN reported 390 aid workers killed in 2024, the highest toll ever recorded, and humanitarian groups warn 2026 is set to be worse still, with more aid workers coming under attack – killed, injured, kidnapped, or detained.

Palestinians account for close to a fifth of all aid workers killed since records began. Impunity compounds the crisis: attacks go uninvestigated, perpetrators unpunished, and humanitarian access is increasingly treated as a bargaining chip rather than a legal obligation under international humanitarian law. Reversing this requires more than tributes. Warring parties and states must be held to the Geneva Conventions' protections for humanitarian personnel, with credible investigation and prosecution of attacks, not just condemnation.

Humanitarian access needs to be negotiated as non-negotiable, insulated from political leverage. Funding - chronically underpaid and precarious – must shift towards predictable, multi-year support so organisations can retain trained staff rather than burn through them. And local responders, who absorb the greatest risk and know their communities best, deserve a far larger share of both resources and decision-making power than the current aid architecture gives them.

India's own experience offers a useful counterpoint to despair. From Operation Dost's medical teams in earthquake-hit Turkey and Syria in 2023, to Operation Brahma in Myanmar and Operation Sagar Bandhu's rescue of over 2,500 citizens and treatment of 2,200 patients after Cyclone Ditwah in Sri Lanka in 2025, to Operation Amistad's earthquake response in Venezuela this year, India has steadily built a reputation as a first responder abroad – backed at home by the NDRF's disaster machinery. Indeed, humanitarian capacity, built patiently, becomes a form of soft power rooted in something sturdier than diplomacy alone.

India's middle class needs opportunity more than subsidies

The World Economic Forum estimates make this even clearer. Today, 4 out of every 5 rupees spent by Indian consumers come from middle-class and better-off families. By 2036, that is expected to increase to more than 9 out of every 10 rupees. By 2047, this group is projected to include over one billion Indians



ASHOK KUMAR MITTAL

income tax in full, on time, every year. The mother has taken a loan for their daughter's engineering degree. There is an insurance premium due each March against an illness they hope never comes. This family asks the government for very little. It is the Indian middle class, and it has quietly become the engine of the country's economy – and the government's own record over the past decade shows it understands that the next phase of reform must focus on this family.

Yet, few people realise just how powerful this engine has become. Speaking in France earlier this year, the finance minister pointed out that India's middle class has expanded by about 6.3 per cent every year since 1995 and now forms roughly 31 per cent of the population. The World Economic Forum estimates make this even clearer. Today, 4 out of every 5 rupees spent by Indian consumers come from middle-class and better-off families. By 2036, that is expected to increase to more than 9 out of every 10 rupees. By 2047, this group is projected to include over one billion Indians.

The growth of the middle class is also reflected in India's tax base. The number of income-tax payers has more than doubled, from 5.26 crore in 2013-14 to 12.13 crore in 2024-25, and Income Tax Return filings have doubled in the same period, from 4 crore in 2013-14 to 8.18 crore in 2023-24, according to the Press Information Bureau. That is what happens when a tax system is simplified rather than merely enforced.

Healthcare tells a similar story. As government spending on healthcare has increased, families are paying much less from their own pockets for medical treatment. Out-of-pocket healthcare expenses have fallen from 64.2 per cent in 2013-14 to 39.4 per cent today, while public spending on healthcare has steadily increased. And even as the economy has formalised at record pace, the labour market has held steady: the National Statistical Office's Periodic Labour Force Survey puts the overall unemployment rate at 3.1 per cent in 2025, among the lowest such figures India has ever recorded.

The government's next priority is to create more quality jobs that match people's education and skills, especially for graduates. With graduate unemployment at 11.2 per cent, the focus is now on better experiential learning and stronger links between education and industry.

So, what does such a family need from the government now? Not more help. Welfare matters, and India has extended it to the poor on a scale no country has attempted before. But the middle class stands somewhere else, and policy has increasingly recognised this. It has never asked to be carried. It asks only that the climb be made possible. A subsidy answers a shortage; opportunity answers an ambition – and the direction of recent policy suggests the government agrees.

Helping people through welfare and helping them create



wealth are two different approaches. Welfare is measured by what the government distributes out. Wealth creation is measured by what people are able to earn. A family that has already escaped poverty needs the second far more than the first – and the government's recent reforms have leaned decisively toward the second.

That shift is well underway. Incomes of up to 12 lakh rupees a year are now free of income tax, GST has been rationalised into simpler slabs, and the Income Tax Act of 1961 has at last been replaced after decades of complexity. Each of these reforms allows middle-class families to keep more of what they earn, instead of paying it to the government first and receiving it as benefits later. More Indians are joining the formal economy and as a result the number of GST taxpayers has risen from 66.5 lakh in 2017 to 1.64 crore by April 2026 – nearly two and a half times in nine years, according to the Press Information Bureau.

Lower taxes help families keep more of their income. Better jobs help them increase that income. That is why the government's recent investments have focused on creating more employment opportunities. Twelve semiconductor projects have been cleared, carrying an investment of about

1.64 lakh crore rupees (roughly \$19 billion). The IndiaAI Mission has built a shared national computing facility of more than 45,000 GPUs, the machines on which artificial intelligence model is trained. Electronics are now worth 13 lakh crore rupees (about \$155 billion) and stand as India's third-largest export.

India already ranks among the world's largest producers of renewable power. Every solar park and battery plant creates opportunities for engineers, technicians and supervisors. To ensure these opportunities translate into prosperity, the government's focus is now on equipping Indians

with the skills needed for these emerging industries. According to the India Skills Report 2026, only 56.35 per cent of graduates are currently considered employable. The government's skill development and apprenticeship programmes, including Skill India and the National Education Policy's focus on vocational education, are aimed at improving this figure. India has spent the past decade building industries such as semiconductors, artificial intelligence and renewable energy. The next challenge is to prepare more graduates for these sectors by improving skills and reducing graduate unemployment, which currently stands at 11.2 per cent.

Colleges must therefore keep teaching for jobs and not only for degrees. Employers should help write the syllabus and sit on examination panels. Students should gain hands-on industry experience as part of their degree, not after completing it. And learning must continue throughout one's career because the skills of 2026 will not be enough for the jobs of tomorrow.

Not every middle-class Indian wants a salary. Many want to build something, and the government schemes have already begun making that easier: streamlined MSME registration through Udyam, credit guarantees through CGTMSE, and invoice discounting through TReDS. However, there is still considerable scope to improve access to bank credit for small businesses. Encouragingly, the share of small enterprises receiving formal bank loans increased from 14 per cent in 2020 to 20 per cent in 2024, according to NITI Aayog. If this progress continues, many more entrepreneurs will be able to access the finance they need to grow.

Healthcare and education costs can also hold families back. When they must take loans for these essential needs, pursuing bigger dreams often becomes financially risky. The government's own record is its strongest case – reliable roads and power, dependable government hospitals, good government schools and honest digital services hand that money back to the family. And out-of-pocket health spending's fall from 64.2 per cent in 2013-14 to 39.4 per cent today shows the direction is already right. India is now close to achieving the National Health Policy's target of reducing out-of-pocket healthcare expenses to 35 per cent.

Somewhere in an Indian city, that same father is still filing his return on time, that same mother is still repaying her daughter's loan. Neither has asked the state for a handout, and increasingly, neither has had to. What the middle class deserves – and what the reforms of the past decade have sought to deliver – is not charity, but opportunity. It is a job worth training for, a business worth risking, a city that does not tax them twice by making them pay privately for what public money already promised. Perhaps the question is no longer whether India's middle class can carry the weight of Viksit Bharat – India's goal of becoming a developed nation by 2047 – for it has been carrying that weight quietly for thirty years, and today, more than ever, government policies are helping share that responsibility.

The writer is Member of Parliament, Rajya Sabha and Founder Chancellor, Lovely Professional University

PIC TALK



People dance during the '61st annual Diggi Kalyan Ji Lakhi Padyatra', a religious pilgrimage to Diggi Kalyan Ji Temple, in Jaipur. PHOTO: PTI

Jason Arday and the cost of believing a good story



KUSHAN MITRA

2ND OPINION

For some strange reason, my social media feeds have been serving up the Jason Arday matter quite relentlessly on my feeds for the past few weeks. For those of you who are not aware, Jason Arday was a Professor in the department of education at Cambridge University, one of the most hallowed educational institutions on the planet. In fact, he was the youngest black professor in the history of Cambridge University. But it turned out that not only had Arday falsified and plagiarised his entire educational history, his life history turned out to be too good to be true. And despite claiming to have overcome adversity, achieving some amazing things, including being unable to verbally communicate until he was 18, he took his own life when his house of cards just collapsed literally overnight.

There are two things that strike me, the first is trying to

find the right adjective to describe this sorry affair. Yes, it is tragic, but if this was a Detective story, I used have used the term 'curious'. And certainly had Arday not decided to take his own life, this story would have been comedic as well. I found it truly peculiar that someone could make such outlandish claims without being fact-checked. Especially in a world where people get fact-checked almost instantly on social media. The very claim that he ran six marathons in six days could and should have been checked, and it would have been very easy to do so in an era of pervasive digital media. His claim of being on a popular television show was immediately debunked. His claims of Autism and being non-verbal could have been checked with fellow students and primary school teachers. And all of this and more was eventually debunked, a stunning article in *The Guardian* of all places effectively called him a liar, which Arday certainly was. This is a man who claimed to have overcome incredible adversity such as having a brain tumour removed a couple of weeks before his viva for his doctorate leading him to relearn it all. Oh, come on. Some of his outlandish claims couldn't be proven by CCTV or other records.

Yet, Cambridge University hired him, and the entire story is not really an indictment of Jason Arday, it is of Cambridge University and his enablers. And this is where the lesson lies, not just for institutes of excellence like Cambridge certainly was once upon a time, but public life in general.

We have let a whole class of liars and charlatans take

over public life, in the process devaluing many, many things. At the same time, we have a public, and even people in positions of power so desperate to believe any story that often despite evidence to the contrary, they will double down using standard forms of defence such as racism and in India, casteism, and that global phenomenon, whataboutery.

And I am not indicting any one side, this is as true on the right as it is on the left. Human beings in general like a feel-good origin story, in politics, in sports and clearly in education. In India as well, we always find that one kid who cleared a major entrance despite studying under a street-light even though the overwhelming majority of such children do not succeed.

It is terrible that Arday took his own life, he could have and should have been stopped earlier by any number of people, because as someone might say, 'The Math did not Math' in his case. And even the fantasy world that he created could easily have been debunked and he might have gotten the mental help that he clearly needed and it is truly ironic that a man who claimed he overcame incredible odds and adversity could not face up to real adversity the first time in his life that he likely faced it. The real tragedy will be that we won't learn any lessons from this as a society. We will still let charlatans play with our emotions because who doesn't like a good story.

The writer is Director, Printer and Publisher of *The Pioneer*

MAKKAH ARRANGEMENT MUST BE JUDGED BY PRACTICAL COOPERATION

With reference to the article "The Makkah Triangle and the Iran Test" (August 18), the emerging security understanding among Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Türkiye deserves attention, but it would be unwise to treat it as a formal military alliance before its commitments become clearer. The real test will come if one member faces a serious confrontation with Iran or another regional power. The three countries have different strategic priorities and relationships with major powers, which could make collective action difficult during a crisis.

The arrangement would be more useful if it develops practical mechanisms for consultation rather than ambitious promises of mutual defence. Regular meetings among defence officials, intelligence-sharing on terrorism and maritime security, joint disaster-response exercises and

communication channels during emergencies would be sensible first steps. Such cooperation could strengthen regional stability without creating another rigid bloc. It would also reduce misunderstandings at a time when West Asian tensions remain high.

India should watch these developments carefully, its relations with Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Iran and other Gulf countries are important for energy security, trade and the welfare of millions of Indian citizens. New Delhi should continue engaging all sides while encouraging dialogue and de-escalation. The Makkah arrangement can become constructive if it remains flexible, transparent and focused on common security concerns. Its credibility should be measured by what it prevents and resolves, not by rhetoric.

M BARATHI | BENGALURU

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

India's press freedom ranking

India, despite being the world's largest democracy with regular elections and constitutional guarantees of free speech, ranks 157th out of 180 countries in the 2026 World Press Freedom Index released by Reporters Without Borders (RSF). India ranked 151st in 2025, marking a six-place decline. The ranking raises serious concerns about the challenges faced by Indian journalism. Journalists reportedly face harassment, legal pressure and intimidation, while concentration of media ownership and economic dependence on government advertising and corporate sponsorship can affect editorial independence and encourage self-censorship.

At the same time, India continues to have a vast and diverse media ecosystem, with hundreds of television channels and thousands of newspapers and publications in multiple languages. Digital platforms and social media are also becoming increasingly important sources of news, particularly for younger audiences.

Press freedom is essential to a healthy democracy. The latest ranking should therefore be viewed not merely as a statistic but as an opportunity to examine the conditions under which journalists work and to strengthen protections for independent journalism, editorial freedom and responsible reporting.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Vande Mataram should remain a symbol of unity

Apropos of the editorial "Vande Mataram Does Not Deserve Political Slugfest", published on August 18. The recent controversy over the rendition of Vande Mataram, whether only the first two stanzas or all six should be sung, and who insulted the song at various events has needlessly turned a unifying national symbol into a partisan battleground.

Vande Mataram, our national song, was written in 1875, while *Jana Gana Mana*, the national anthem, was written in 1911. *Vande Mataram* has been part of our national consciousness long before this controversy. It is sung in schools and featured in films.

The 1937 Congress decision to adopt only the opening stanzas for official functions was an inclusive compromise. What we are witnessing now is not a genuine debate about patriotism, but a contest over political ownership of a shared heritage. The BJP and Congress should move beyond this slugfest and focus on pressing issues such as the NTA, education, healthcare and employment.

It is ironic that a song that once united people across faiths and religions has divided them along party lines. The least our leaders can do is let *Vande Mataram* remain a symbol of unity.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

Food safety in quick commerce

There is an urgent need to look at the growing food-safety concerns accompanying India's rapid quick-commerce expansion. The suspension of 14 food business licences linked to major delivery platforms by the Maharashtra government is a serious warning that convenience cannot come at the cost of consumer health.

Quick-commerce companies are not merely technology platforms. Their dark stores and warehouses handle food, manage inventory and control storage and delivery. They must therefore accept clear responsibility for hygiene, freshness, temperature control and quality. Incidents involving expired products, pests, rotten food and inadequate sanitation reveal weaknesses that demand immediate correction. Regulators must also strengthen their systems through uniform inspections, regular audits, cold-chain monitoring and digital tracking of food products.

Most importantly, consumers deserve transparency about where and how their food is stored before it reaches their homes. Speed is undoubtedly the biggest attraction of quick commerce, but it should never override safety. The industry can sustain public trust only when every minute saved in delivery is matched by uncompromising attention to food hygiene and consumer well-being.

VANDANA | CHANDIGARH

Choosing India's youth over political acrimony

Prime Minister Narendra Modi continues to expand educational opportunities through reform and strengthen the integrity of competitive examinations. He sends a clear message: the future belongs to India's youth, and their aspirations must remain at the centre of governance



PRAMOD SAWANT

India's youth are not merely the country's demographic advantage; they are its greatest national asset. Every competitive examination, every innovation, every start-up, every scientific breakthrough and every sporting achievement reflects the aspirations of a generation determined to shape the nation's future.

When examination irregularities caused concern among students, that concern was understandable. Those who prepare for years deserve a system that is fair and trustworthy. At demonstrations, including those held at Jantar Mantar, many students voiced legitimate concerns about examination integrity. Yet alongside these genuine voices, some individuals resorted to abusive personal slogans directed at Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji and his family. Slogans advocating confrontation rather than constructive dialogue received media attention, but they did not define the aspirations of India's youth.

The overwhelming majority of Gen Z Indians were not on the streets hurling insults. They were in libraries, classrooms, coaching centres and homes, preparing for their next examination, chasing their careers and striving to build their future. They deserve to be recognised as the true face of India's youth. A statesman understands this distinction.

Rather than allowing personal attacks to dominate the national conversation, PM Shri Prime Minister Modi chose to remain focused on the larger issue: the future of India's students.

This ability to absorb criticism without losing sight of governance is what distinguishes political leadership from statesmanship. Democracies will always witness passionate disagreement, and criticism is a natural part of public life. Leadership, however, is ultimately judged by whether personal attacks are allowed to distract from national priorities.

For over a decade, PM Shri Narendra Modi has consistently placed young Indians at the centre of his governance. Through Pariksha Pe Charcha, he has transformed the conversation around examinations, encouraging students to approach them with confidence, curiosity and emotional resilience rather than fear. His interactions extend beyond marks and rankings to mental well-being, time management and self-belief. Similarly, Mann Ki Baat has become a platform where young achievers find national recognition;

HISTORY OFTEN REMEMBERS LEADERS NOT FOR THE INSULTS THEY RECEIVED BUT FOR THE RESTRAINT THEY DISPLAYED IN RESPONDING TO THEM. STATESMANSHIP LIES NOT IN WINNING EVERY POLITICAL ARGUMENT BUT IN REFUSING TO LET PERSONAL ATTACKS OVERSHADOW NATIONAL PRIORITIES

The writer is Chief Minister of Goa

student innovators, start-up founders, grassroots inventors, young scientists, sportspersons and social entrepreneurs alike, reinforcing the message that India's future will be shaped by its youth rather than by political division.

The Union Government has also worked to strengthen the ecosystem in which students compete, introducing structural reforms to strengthen confidence in public examinations. It has enacted a stringent law against unfair practices in public examinations, providing severe penalties for organised paper-leak rackets and those who facilitate examination fraud. It has strengthened coordination among central agencies and examination bodies, enhanced digital surveillance, encryption and the secure transport of question papers, and tightened cybersecurity for computer-based tests. Firm action against organised cheating networks, middlemen and complicit officials, together with stronger accountability mechanisms, is intended to ensure that future examinations are conducted with greater transparency and credibility.

The Modi Government's vision for youth extends even beyond examinations. The National Education Policy 2020 seeks to equip students with multidisciplinary learning, critical thinking and greater flexibility. Programmes such as PM Gati Shakti envision new economic opportunities through world-class infrastructure, creating jobs and enabling young entrepreneurs to join India's growth story. Digital India, Start-up India, Skill India, semiconductor manufacturing, artificial intelligence, drone technology and space-sector reforms are all designed with the aspirations of Gen Z in mind. The philosophy is consistent: invest in the capabilities of young Indians rather than merely manage their expectations.

The contrast is significant. While a handful of motivated voices may seek attention through provocative slogans, the aspirations of India's youth lie elsewhere. They seek quality education, employment opportunities, technological advancement and a nation that rewards merit. Prime Minister Modi's response reflected an understanding of this distinction. Rather than treating every angry slogan as representative of an entire generation, he separated a few disruptive voices from the millions of sincere students pursuing their dreams, demonstrating confidence in India's youth instead of cynicism towards them.

History often remembers leaders not for the insults they received but for the restraint they displayed in responding to them. Statesmanship lies not in winning every political argument but in refusing to let personal attacks overshadow national priorities. A leader who continues to engage with students through *Pariksha Pe Charcha*, celebrates young achievers in Mann Ki Baat, expands educational opportunity through reform and strengthens the integrity of competitive examinations sends a clear message: the future belongs to India's youth, and their aspirations must remain at the centre of governance.

That, ultimately, is the measure of leadership, not the ability to answer every provocation, but the willingness to rise above it in service of the nation.

World humanitarian day: Remembering unsung heroes



SATENDRA SINGH

Humanitarian Day, holds so much relevance to India today. The day, observed by the United Nations, pays tribute to humanitarian workers who risk their lives while helping people suffering from any disaster, conflict or other crisis. However, humanitarian action means much more than aid work done in times of such emergencies. In India, humanitarian efforts are those of NDRF and SDRF workers, firefighters, police, armed forces, medical professionals, district authorities, NGOs, volunteers and local communities. In many disaster situations, the initial humanitarian response comes from a neighbour.

The local fisherman may help a family get out of a dangerous situation. The villagers may be the first to search through the rubble of a collapsed building.

The increasing complexity of these disasters, however, poses an enormous burden on this system of response. The relevant question here is no longer limited to how fast we will be able to offer assistance after the disaster has occurred. What we need to ask ourselves is whether we will be able to react to a predicted hazard before it causes a humanitarian crisis.

People behind the response

In case of any disaster, the general public tends to see the rescue operations. What is less visible is the large network of people working behind these operations. They are the humanitarian workers. They are the ones who operate in some of the toughest and most dangerous environments. Most of them continue their jobs even when other people try to escape from there. World Humanitarian Day is a chance to remember these people. However, this day should also serve as a reminder that the humanitarian response is not the responsibility of a particular department. It is a collective process.

Over the last two decades, India has developed its unique disaster response system. The National Disaster Response Force, State Disaster Response Forces, armed forces, police force, fire services, civil defence, health authorities, district administration, NGOs and community organisations all play their part. All these agencies' combined efforts have saved many lives during various disasters such as floods, cyclones, earthquakes and landslides. However, there is a paradigm shift taking place in relation to disasters. While a disaster could previously be restricted to one locality or even one sector, today, a cloudburst may lead to a flash flood that leads to a landslide, causing the destruction of bridges, power outages and communication failures, disrupting hospitals and isolating communities.

There is also the impact of climate change, which has increased the level of uncertainty. It is important that preparedness does not just revolve around post-disaster actions but needs to take place long before such events occur.

One of the most significant shifts is that between early warning and early action. India has made huge strides in terms of forecasting and early warning mechanisms in respect of cyclones, evacuation, river and rainfall monitoring, among others. However, the real success of an early warning lies in its translation into action. An alert posted on a government website will not save lives. It needs to get through to the farmer, the fisherman, the tourist, the schoolteacher, the village head and the family residing in a vulnerable settlement. More importantly, they need to understand what the alert means and what they have to do. This is where the participation of local communities comes into play. Communities should not be treated merely as beneficiaries of relief. They need to be trained to participate in the process of disaster management.

It is worth noting one more thing that requires our greater attention - the well-being of humanitarian workers themselves. Disaster responders spend many hours in a very difficult physical and emotional state because they have to deal with unsafe buildings, floodwaters, landslides, fire, extreme temperature changes and diseases. The life of a disaster responder is always at risk while helping other people. The disaster responder needs proper education, protection, communication systems, insurance, rest and psychological help. A resilient disaster management system has to protect those who are protecting us.

Humanitarian response is not only about the number of rescue teams working or relief materials sent out to the disaster-affected area. It is about saving people from unnecessary suffering and helping them to restore their lives. The humanitarian worker is thus no longer just a saviour; he or she is a connection between disaster and hope.

With the increasing complexity and unpredictability of disasters, it is imperative that the Indian government develops a humanitarian system where humanitarian assistance starts not once a community is in distress, but even before disaster strikes. With the increased occurrence of disasters comes the question: What sort of humanitarian assistance and response system does India require in the coming years? There is no denying the fact that India has done well on its side to develop its disaster management systems. With bodies like the National Disaster Management Authority, National Disaster Response Force, State Disaster Management Authorities and district administrations developing their preparedness and response capacity, a lot is being done in this regard. But more is required. It is time that we move from responding to disasters to reducing risks before disaster strikes.

The writer is former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management



Zardari's minority claims: A far cry from reality



SUDHIR SINGH

erates. We have a 4 per cent Hindu population in Pakistan. They are free as anywhere else. They would rather be with us than India." At first look, this position of Zardari seems benevolent and secular. But the reality is something different.

Official Pakistani census records tell an entirely different story regarding demographic trends. The Hindu share of the population in territories that became Pakistan has dropped sharply, from roughly 15 per cent in the 1941 census to 2.17 per cent (5.2 million) in the 2023 census, depending on the categories and regions counted. According to the Pakistan Hindu Council, the actual number of Hindus is between 8 to 10 million, arguing that many Hindus are missed or deliberately uncounted in the 2023 official census. As per the 2023 census, 49 lakh Hindus live in Sindh, making up almost 9 per cent of the overall population of the province. Punjab has 2.5 lakh, Balochistan 59,107, Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa 6,104 and

Islamabad Capital Territory 839.

Before Partition (1947), in today's Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, particularly as per the 1941 British India census, 15 per cent Hindus and Sikhs were residing. During the tragedy of Partition, they were killed and those left over were compelled to embark on compulsory migration to India. As per the 2023 census, almost zero Hindus live in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. Although the 1973 Bhutto Constitution of Pakistan provides equal rights to all citizens and is not supposed to discriminate on the basis of caste, creed or religion.

Pakistan came into being on the philosophy that Hindus and Muslims were two different faiths and could not live together. By 1940, Mohammed Ali Jinnah became the sole spokesperson for the Muslims of undivided Bharat. In the historic Lahore Resolution, the 'Two-Nation Theory' was moved by a Bengali Muslim, AK Fazal Huq, and passed by the Jinnah-led Muslim League in March 1940. Muhammad Ali Jinnah argued during the Lahore Resolution in his presidential address that 'Hindus and Muslims were distinct nations that could not coexist in a single Indian framework'. In the larger context, the Lahore Resolution became the philosophical ground for the Partition of India and the creation of Pakistan. Perhaps in any corner of the globe, within the ambit of seven years (1940-1947), a nation has been created. The new nation came into being as Pakistan. However, later Jinnah modified his stance and argued for an inclu-



sive Pakistan in his address to the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan. Khawaja Nizamuddin, the 2nd Prime Minister of Pakistan, stated in the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan: "I do not agree that religion is a private affair of the individual nor do I agree that in an Islamic state every citizen has identical rights, no matter what his caste, creed or faith be."

Article 41 (2) of the Constitution of the

Parliament. The number of National Assembly seats has today gone from 207 in 1997 to 336 in the 2024 election, but seats for minorities have not been increased in this proportion due to opposition from the forces known as harbingers of 'Political Islam'. Hindus are not duly represented in diverse walks of life and face multiple forms of discrimination, including forced conversion, rape of their women and

Islamic State of Pakistan explicitly states that a person is not qualified for election as President (head of the state) unless he is a Muslim. This provision exclusively debars Hindus from becoming President of Pakistan, which is otherwise not possible due to their minuscule population and the prominence of 'Political Islam'. Pakistan's Constitution's Article 51 (2A) provides 10 reserved seats for non-Muslims in the National Assembly, 23 reserved seats for non-Muslims in four provincial assemblies under Article 106, and four seats for non-Muslims in the Senate of Pakistan. Conventionally, Hindus were allocated 4-5 seats in the Pakistani

many such others. In education, they are also deprived because of the structure of the syllabus.

In contrast, Muslims in India were 9.8 per cent per the 1951 census and increased up to 14.2 per cent per the 2011 census. Muslims in India became President three times; Union Cabinet ministers, Governors and many became Chief Ministers in Hindu-majority provinces like Bihar and Maharashtra. Muslims and other Indian minorities are duly represented in all walks of life. Hindi cinema has been unprecedentedly led by Muslim artists. Parsis are a minuscule minority in India, but they are leading the Indian economy.

Swami Vivekananda stated in his famous 1893 Chicago address that, since ages, India has accommodated all shades of minorities. We believe in accommodation, not toleration, Zardari. We do not need to be lectured by President Asif Ali Zardari about the rights of minorities. Our Constitution treats each citizen on the basis of equality. After 80 years of our democratic experience, we have proved the 'Two-Nation Theory' wrong. After Indonesia, the largest number of Muslims are living in India with dignity and a sense of belongingness. Pakistan must learn from India on many fronts, including the fair treatment of its minorities.

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Order Order

Calcutta High Court dismisses PIL on mosque loudspeakers



The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday dismissed a PIL, which alleged that loudspeakers were being removed from mosques in parts of West Bengal.

A division bench headed by Acting Chief Justice Tapabrata Chakraborty dismissed the petition, holding that there was no written instruction by the state authorities.

Senior advocate Kalyan Banerjee, who moved the petition, had alleged that loudspeakers were being removed from mosques in the state following oral instructions from authorities.

The bench, also comprising Justice Atarup Banerjee, said that the petitioner could not produce any written order in this regard.

Advocate General Surojit Nath Mitra told the court that there was no such order issued by the authorities.

It was also stated that there was no meeting between imams of mosques and the police authorities in this regard as alleged by the petitioner. (PTI)

SC defers PIL hearing on Odisha DGP appointment



The Supreme Court on Tuesday deferred to September 2 the hearing on a PIL which alleged that the Odisha Government was trying to include a junior officer in the list of probable candidates for the DGP post in breach of the apex court's directions in the 2006 Prakash Singh case.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was informed by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Odisha Government, that the state has filed its response to the PIL.

The bench said that the reply of the state Government was not on record. The CJI said that he would like to go through the reply of the state Government. The bench then deferred the hearing on the plea to September 2.

Earlier, the top court had asked the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) not to finalise till August 18 the names of probable officers for appointment of the Director General of Police of Odisha.

It was hearing the PIL which alleged that the state Government was trying to include a junior officer in the list of probable candidates for the DGP post.

The incumbent DGP, YB Khurania, was to demit office on August 16.

Senior advocate P Chidambaram, appearing for the petitioner, had told the bench that an officer of the rank of ADGP was promoted in Odisha. (PTI)

Allahabad HC directs UP Govt to form fresh panel for welfare of advocates' clerks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court on Tuesday directed the Uttar Pradesh Government to constitute a fresh committee to examine the problems and welfare needs of the advocates' clerks, who play an important role in the functioning of the judicial system.

The Allahabad High Court's Lucknow bench comprising Justices Alok Mathur and Amitabh Kumar Rai earlier rejected the recommendations of a committee constituted in January 2021, observing that most of its members apparently did not have adequate knowledge of the nature of work performed by the advocates' clerks, their remuneration, responsibilities and their role in the administration of justice.

The court passed the order on a petition filed in 2017 by Sushil Kumar Srivastava, seeking direc-



tions to the State to formulate a welfare policy for the advocates' clerks.

The petitioner submitted that the advocates' clerks perform several crucial functions, including assisting lawyers with secretarial work, filing cases, coordinating with court registries, obtaining certified copies and removing defects in petitions.

Despite this, they generally do not have access to social security, medical benefits or pension. Even after



State cannot take life against human dignity: Supreme Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said the State, even when authorised to take away life, cannot do so in a manner that is arbitrary, excessive or incompatible with human dignity.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said the method of execution must satisfy the constitutional requirements that it minimises suffering and preserves, to the greatest extent possible, the inherent dignity of the condemned.

The bench made the observations while dismissing a petition seeking abolition of the practice of executing a death row convict by hanging and replacing it with methods such as intravenous lethal injection.

In its verdict, the top court said among all punishments permitted by the law, death penalty stands apart in its severity and finality.

"When a court of law, upon due adjudication, imposes a sentence of death for a crime, the State, through its constitutional machinery, is called upon to carry out a punishment of the gravest nature, one that, once executed, is incapable of being undone," it said.

The bench said if an error occurs, whether in the process or the proportionality of punishment, the con-



sequences cannot be undone. "It is this final and irreversible character of death penalty that has placed it at the centre of continuing debate in constitutional law, criminal jurisprudence and moral philosophy, both in India and across jurisdictions," it said, adding that legitimacy of the death penalty has been debated over centuries.

It said that in India, the question of legality of capital punishment has been examined through the prism of constitutional scrutiny, beginning with a decision of the top court that affirmed that death penalty did not violate the guarantees under Articles 14, 19, or 21 of the Constitution, provided it was imposed upon conclusion of a lawful trial with robust procedural safeguards.

The bench said in the pre-

colonial period, the administration of criminal punishment across the country was neither uniform nor governed by any codified legal standard.

It said while the Indian Penal Code, 1860, provided the legal authority to impose death penalty, it was the Code of Criminal Procedure, 1861, that first established 'hanging by the neck' as the sole method to carry it out.

"This selection was framed as a humanitarian reform of the era, utilising the long-drop technique. The method was premised on a clinical calculation of the condemned's height and weight to ensure a fracture of the cervical vertebrae, purportedly resulting in instantaneous loss of consciousness and life," it said.

The bench said the legal mechanism for execution

remains unchanged across more than a century and a half of statutory progressions.

Referring to a Constitution bench verdict, the bench noted it had firmly established that the right to life includes the right to live with human dignity up to the end of natural life, which necessarily encompasses the right to die with dignity.

"This constitutional protection does not cease to exist at the gallows, it must apply with equal emphasis to prisoners who are on death row," it said.

The bench said the issue before it was not one about the existence of the State's power to impose capital punishment, which stands recognised in law, but the limits within which that power must operate.

It said the exercise of such power is necessarily conditioned by constitutional safeguards.

"The State, even when authorised to take life, cannot do so in a manner that is arbitrary, excessive, or incompatible with human dignity," it said.

The bench said when this petition was taken up for consideration in October 2017, the apex court had issued notice and observed that constitutional perspectives are not static and that the Constitution is a living and evolving instrument.

If sitting CM commits an offence, can CBI investigate it? ED asks SC to decide



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate on Tuesday urged the Supreme Court to decide whether the CBI can investigate or not if an offence is committed by a sitting chief minister.

A bench of justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and NV Anjaria was hearing a plea filed by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) alleging obstruction by the then West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee and other state authorities during its January 8 search of the office of political consultancy firm I-PAC in Kolkata.

At the outset, senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy, appearing for TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee, submitted that now that the Government has changed, the prayer for sanction and transfer to local police can be done by the state

Government and nothing remains in the matter. At this juncture, Justice Mishra remarked that pursuant to the subsequent changes (in regime), nothing remains and the matter can be disposed of by allowing the ED's prayer for the transfer of investigation to the CBI.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the ED, requested the court that the larger issue must be decided.

"We don't want to face any allegations that the state Government, because of political reasons, has done it. Either we are right or wrong; I want the court to decide. I don't wish to fall in the death trap that, subsequent to the changes in the Government, the state transferred it to the CBI," Mehta said.

Additional Solicitor General SV Raju contended that the court must decide whether the CBI can investigate a sitting chief minister if an offence is committed.

Uddhav to SC: Decide disqualification pleas before Shiv Sena's fate

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Uddhav Thackeray-led faction of the Shiv Sena told the Supreme Court on Tuesday that the Election Commission's (EC) determination as to which group constitutes the political party should come after a decision on the disqualification proceedings against the MLAs who have deserted their camp.

The submissions to this effect were made by senior advocate Kapil Sibal, representing the Thackeray faction, before a bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya

Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana.

The bench was hearing final arguments on the sixth day on the pleas of the Thackeray faction against the EC's decision to recognise the Eknath Shinde-led camp as the real Shiv Sena and allot the party's name and "bow-and-arrow" symbol to it.

Sibal said the EC and the Maharashtra Assembly speaker had fundamentally misinterpreted the law by conflating a "legislative majority" with the "political party" itself.

He raised a crucial procedural point regarding the timing of the EC's interven-



tion and argued that the poll panel should only determine which faction constitutes the "real" party after the disquali-

fication proceedings against the rebel MLAs are concluded. "If those MLAs are ultimately disqualified, their

strength in the legislature must be disregarded," Kapil Sibal said.

"The process of determining who constitutes the political party must be consequential upon the decision in the disqualification petitions. Otherwise, this problem will arise every time a faction will approach the EC to bypass disqualification," the senior lawyer said.

He said the number of rebel MLAs facing disqualification notices grew from 16 to 22 and eventually, to 39 for various violations, including defying party whips during the speaker's election and the subsequent confidence

motion. He assailed the January 10, 2024, decision of the speaker, which dismissed the disqualification petitions and recognised the Shinde faction as the "real" Shiv Sena based on its majority in the Assembly.

Sibal said the speaker exceeded his jurisdiction by disregarding the 2018 leadership structure of the Shiv Sena.

The speaker had said the 2018 party constitution was "not in conformity" with the Shiv Sena's actual structure, a claim Sibal dismissed as having no legal basis under the 10th Schedule of the Constitution.

SC directs for proper upkeep of captive elephants

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said that elephants must be treated and respected as manifestation of divinity and directed for their proper upkeep and health checkups when in captivity across the country.

Hearing a PIL filed by an NGO, a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said the court will not delve into religious rights or the faith behind the use of captive elephants in temples.

The bench said it was only concerned with the proper



upkeep of the animal and best practices must be adopted for captive elephants by private individuals, temples, forest depart-

ments, zoos and rehabilitation centres. "We are not going into whether a temple can possess an elephant. We are not going into any

personal rights or religious rights. What we need to do is harmoniously deal with religious rights and the other laws operating in the field," it said, adding that the respect to divinity must be extended to elephants also.

The bench directed the Centre to issue mandatory guidelines, as required, and take up the matter with the concerned states to introduce an effective and transparent mechanism on the establishment of elephant clinics with specialised facilities, where it shall be compulsorily prescribed for all owners of captive elephants to take the animals for periodic check-ups.

It said a proper medical record of each captive elephant shall be duly maintained and the monitoring committee shall ensure that treatment, wherever required, is provided regularly.

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, placed on record a February 25 office memorandum on the proceedings of the Captive Elephants Healthcare and Welfare Committee (CEHCW), which pointed out that the number of captive elephants in the country has increased to 2,725.

Bombay HC cancels bail of Goa nightclub owners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday cancelled the bail granted to the owners and a business partner of Birch by Romeo Lane nightclub in Goa, where a devastating fire had claimed 25 lives last December. A single bench of Justice Dr Neela Gokhale passed the order while hearing applications challenging the bail granted to the accused earlier by a trial court.

On December 6, 2025, a fire killed 25 people and injured 50 at the Birch by Romeo Lane nightclub in Arpora, Goa. Saurav and Gaurav Luthra, along with their business partner Ajay Gupta, were partners in M/s Being GS Hospitality Arpora LLP, which operated the nightclub.

The three accused had been granted bail by the trial court in April this year.

The Goa bench of the High Court on Tuesday granted them two weeks to surrender before the trial court, during which they



can seek bail afresh.

"The court has allowed all five applications — one each concerning the three accused in the case of culpable homicide in connection with the fire — and two applications concerning the accused in the forgery case related to obtaining permissions for the nightclub," advocate Somnath Karpe, appearing for the prosecution, told reporters. He said the accused has been granted two weeks to surrender and given liberty to seek bail before the trial court.

The prosecution had challenged the bail granted

to the Luthra brothers and Gupta, arguing that the offences were serious in nature.

The trio was granted bail in the fire case on April 1, while the Luthra brothers were granted bail eight days later in connection with the second FIR relating to alleged forgery in obtaining permissions for the nightclub.

The chargesheet alleged that "irresponsible acts" of the accused resulted in the deaths of 25 people in the mass-casualty incident, causing "irreparable loss" to their families.

Delhi HC denies default bail to 2025 Red Fort car bomb blast accused



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi High Court on Tuesday refused to grant default bail to Jasir Bilal Wani alias Danish, one of the accused in the 2025 Red Fort car bomb blast case.

A bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Vikas Mahajan dismissed Wani's appeal challenging a March 30 trial court order rejecting his plea seeking default bail.

"It is held that the accused is not entitled after 90 days. The appeal is liable to be dismissed," the bench said.

An accused becomes entitled to default bail if the investigating agency fails to file a chargesheet within the stipulated time.

The NIA arrested Wani, a Kashmiri accused of being an "active co-conspirator", in November 2025.

The agency has alleged that Jasir provided technical support for carrying out terror attacks by modifying drones and attempting to make rockets.

It has claimed that he worked closely with suicide bomber Umar un Nabi in planning the Red Fort blast.

A Hyundai i20 car exploded near the Red Fort at 6.52 pm on November 10, 2025, killing 15 people and injuring several others.

INTERVIEW

From classroom learning to workplace readiness

“The real gap is less a content deficit and more a pedagogy deficit,” says Keyoor Purani, Vice Chancellor, Prestige University Indore, in conversation with *The Pioneer*, discussing employability, AI, industry exposure and how universities can prepare graduates for changing careers

India produces millions of graduates every year, yet employers continue to question their job-readiness. Where exactly is the gap between what students learn in college and what the workplace expects from them?

The real gap is less a content deficit and more a pedagogy deficit. Our universities do not necessarily teach too little or too outdated. They are teaching it in ways quite removed from how knowledge is encountered and used at work. University education remains largely subject-centred: learn concepts, reproduce them in examinations, and earn credits. Work is problem-centred. Problems arrive without chapter numbers, cut across disciplines, involve incomplete information and rarely have one correct answer.

The result is a familiar paradox: graduates may know, but may not know what to do with what they know. The missing bridge is application, judgment and context. This is also where industry can play a much more meaningful role - not by telling universities what to teach, but by bringing into education the changing contexts and emerging problems that organisations are confronting.

Employability, therefore, is not about turning universities into training centres for today's jobs. It is about enabling stu-

dents to apply knowledge, question existing practices and eventually create better ones.

Employability is often reduced to technical skills. In your view, which human skills - communication, problem-solving, adaptability, creativity or something else - will matter most for graduates entering an AI-driven workplace?

I think technical skills matter, but they are increasingly becoming temporarily relevant. They may help a graduate secure employment today. Sustained employability will depend much more on enduring human capabilities.

In an AI-driven world, questions may matter more than answers. AI can increasingly generate answers. It can

write, analyse, code, and synthesise. The human advantage lies in knowing what to ask, what to trust, what context is missing, and ultimately, what decision to make.

That makes curiosity, critical thinking and judgment particularly important. Judgment draws upon communication, empathy and ethics as well. It determines how intelligently and responsibly we use what technology gives us. Universities should therefore resist chasing every new tool as a new 'skill'. Tools will keep changing. The quality of questions we ask and the judgment we exercise will remain consequential.

Should universities prepare students for specific professions or teach them to continuously reinvent themselves?

Both. But yes, increasingly the emphasis must shift to reinvention.

We are moving from a lifetime career to a career of a lifetime, spanning multiple roles and industries. A graduate today may work for 40-50 years, and the new generation has no hesitation in shifting careers from investment banking to writing novels and from information technology to starting up yoga training. And hence, no single curriculum can remain sufficient across that span.

Universities must therefore combine disciplinary depth for immediate employability with intellectual breadth and adaptability for long-term relevance. They should function as lifelong



learning ecosystems, not one-time credential providers.

How can a new institution make industry exposure, internships and real-world learning integral to the curriculum rather than an add-on?

A new university has the advantage of fewer legacy constraints, and innovation becomes an important means to accelerate towards excellence. At Prestige University, our Multi-Path Learning Opportunities (MPLO) model, leveraging the flexibility outlined in NEP 2020, allows students to switch tracks as their interests evolve during their education.

We are shifting from industry alignment to industry contribution. For example, our MBA includes extended corporate immersion rather than a short internship. Across programmes, learning is built around live projects, simulations and integrated experiences where theory and practice constantly interact.



such as Coursera, SWAYAM and NPTEL can expand access and enable continuous learning, but a certificate can validate a skill; it cannot substitute for education. Universities should develop people, not merely credentials. Technical competence

may open the first door, but attitude, judgment and the capacity to keep learning determine how far one travels.

For a Class 12 student choosing a degree, what three things should they consider beyond brand name and placements?

One, how will I learn? Look at pedagogy — projects, simulations, internships, research and interdisciplinary exposure, not just the syllabus. Two, who will I learn with and from? Faculty, peers, visiting practitioners and the overall intellectual environment all shape learning.

Three, who will this university help me become? Placement data reflects the first job, not the long journey ahead.

Students should, of course, ask about jobs, but the deeper question is: Will this university prepare me for roles and possibilities that neither I nor even the institution can yet imagine?

Management education is being rewritten

AMOD VIJAYVARGIYA

Director, Pearl Academy School of Business

Management education is undergoing a major overhaul because business is evolving much faster than the traditional classroom. Recruiters today look beyond academic credentials for professionals who have demonstrated adaptability, problem-solving skills. Organisations need managers who can handle unfamiliar problems, interpret data, leverage artificial intelligence, and collaborate across functions.

Experience, not examinations, therefore, has become the new measure of employability. This transformation is reflected in India's latest employability data. As per the India Skills Report 2026, MBA employability declined from 78 per cent to 72.76 per cent in one year. Consequently, experiential learning is no longer an academic innovation; it is becoming the foundation of meaningful management education. The strongest business classrooms today resemble decision-making labs more than lecture halls. Students navigate business simulations, respond to changing market conditions, analyse real-time data, defend strategies before industry practitioners and collaborate across disciplines to solve complex challenges.



Technology has been responsible for driving this change further. Artificial Intelligence (AI) can analyse the business environment, spot trends and generate insights within seconds. However, it still cannot replace judgement, ethical reasoning and leadership. Future managers will not compete with AI. They will compete with people who know how to use AI better. This is why AI, analytics and data-driven decision-making need to form part of management education.

Entrepreneurs and business leaders are increasingly active participants in learning.

The focus is shifting from past case studies to live corporate issues. Whether developing market-entry strategies, solving customer experience issues, or supporting digital transformation, working on live challenges builds confi-

dence, credibility, and professional judgment. The India Skills Report 2025 highlights this demand, showing that 93 percent of over 6.5 lakh surveyed students seek internship-style and real-world learning opportunities.

Ultimately, the future of management education is not about adding new disciplines to the curriculum; it is about offering opportunities to experience business firsthand. Graduates should enter the workforce with a portfolio of decisions made, problems solved, industry collaborations undertaken, and ideas tested. A management degree's value is no longer measured by examinations passed, but by the experience accumulated. Experience is no longer just the reward for getting a job-it is what helps candidates secure the job in the first place.

Cyber law in a fast-changing world

INDRANATH GUPTA

Dean, SRM School of Law, SRMIST

Today, technology has become all-pervasive and unavoidable. The exponential growth of technology has made our lives both easier and more complicated. Owing to the ever-changing nature of technology, the nature of cybercrimes also constantly evolves.

As technology booms at a remarkable speed, it is constantly challenging existing legal avenues. It is challenging the way we have perceived cybercrime in the past, questioning legal curricula and posing obstacles for legal academics in the sub-discipline of cyber law. Effectively implementing the existing legal framework when threats evolve faster is difficult.

In India, legal education has been built around legal principles that have evolved through legislation and judicial interpretation. It is immensely difficult to legislate on cybercrimes when they develop and evolve rapidly. Cybercriminals exploit vulnerabilities and loopholes.

So, in the arena of cyber law, there exist complex legal and ethical dilemmas that demand new perspectives and interpretations from both lawmakers and legal practitioners. This makes cyber law one of the most dynamic and intellectually demanding fields in legal education. The degree programmes concerning cyber law and information technology law must be designed in such a way that students have a holistic understanding of possible cybercrimes. Educators need

to help students not only become legal experts but also provide them with a strong foundation in interdisciplinary studies. Students should be educated on cybercrimes, the laws regulating them, the limitations of these laws and, most importantly, how they can be interpreted to meet emerging challenges. Teaching should focus on legal reasoning, comparative legal frameworks and technological literacy.

In addition to that, one must understand that there is no effective cyber law education

without synchronisation with technology. Students of law need to have a basic understanding of concepts such as digital forensics, cybersecurity, artificial intelligence and more. Being acquainted with technology will help them comprehend legal disputes involving it.

Cybercrimes do not have geographical barriers; this further complicates cyber law education. Many complications arise from scenarios where legal standards do not align. Therefore, students must be exposed to international legal systems and frameworks that shape cybersecurity and safeguard against cybercrime. This will help them function effectively in an interconnected legal world.

The exponential rise in technology has redefined existing legal imagination around privacy, data protection, consent, transparency, accountability and fairness. AI systems have raised unimaginable challenges, such as the amplification of misinformation on several platforms, while deepfake technology can erode public confidence, weaken democratic processes and damage reputations. Therefore, a professor of information technology law or cyber law should encourage students to reflect on ethics alongside legal analysis. This will help students better respond to the challenge of balancing innovation with the implementation of legal rights.

Cyber law doesn't require keeping up with every new technological development. Instead, it needs to equip students with analytical skills, ethical judgement, technological awareness and legal adaptability, so they can respond confidently to change.



Micro-credentials and modular learning: Future of higher education

ANADI SARAN PANDE

Dean of School of Management, Mahindra University

As India works towards its aspiration of becoming a developed nation by 2047, the conversation around higher education is also changing. Universities are focusing on holistic and interdisciplinary education along with experiential learning to build a workforce that is skilled and future-ready.

Reflecting the positive impact of sustained investments in skilling and industry-academia collaboration, employability has risen from 46 per cent in 2020 to 56.4 per cent in 2026, according to India Skills Report 2026.

To equip learners with relevant skills, higher education institutions are complementing traditional degrees with flexible learning pathways by combining academic rigour with practical experience.

With the rapid pace of technological changes and innovation in areas such as artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, data science, advanced manufacturing and sustainability, learning has become a lifelong pursuit.

With India expected to generate a surplus of 45 million skilled professionals by 2030, the challenge will be ensur-

ing that talent remains relevant through continuous learning.

This is where modular learning and micro-credentials find their relevance. Not because they replace traditional degrees, but because they extend the life of a university education beyond graduation.

Micro-credentials are short and focused certifications that validate proficiency in a particular set of skills and are usually delivered as a part of the broader curriculum. Within a relatively short period, they allow learners to gain expertise in targeted domains.

This is complemented by modular learning as it breaks down larger programmes into smaller, credit-bearing units that can be completed over a period. This accumulates into larger qualifications in many cases, giving learners the opportunity to progress at a pace that aligns with their personal and profes-



sional commitments.

Due to growing industry interest in credentials such as artificial intelligence, cybersecurity and data science, more people are opting for them. Professionals who can contribute from day one in dynamic work

environments are valued by employers. The focus is on the shift from what individuals have studied to how effectively they can apply their knowledge to solve real-world challenges.

The World Economic Forum estimates that 39 per cent of workers' core skills will change by 2030. If skills continue to evolve at this pace, the idea that a degree earned at twenty-two will remain sufficient through a forty-year career becomes increasingly difficult to defend. India's own policy reforms acknowledge this shift. The National Education

Policy 2020, along with initiatives such as the Academic Bank of Credits and flexible entry-exit pathways, reflects an important recognition—that learning is rarely linear anymore.

With the country's skilling ecosystem increasingly adopting a life-cycle approach integrating education, apprenticeships, entrepreneurship and lifelong learning, India is well positioned to respond to this shift. For better alignment of education with emerging technologies, academia, industry and government are collaborating and ensuring that graduates remain competitive in an increasingly interconnected economy.

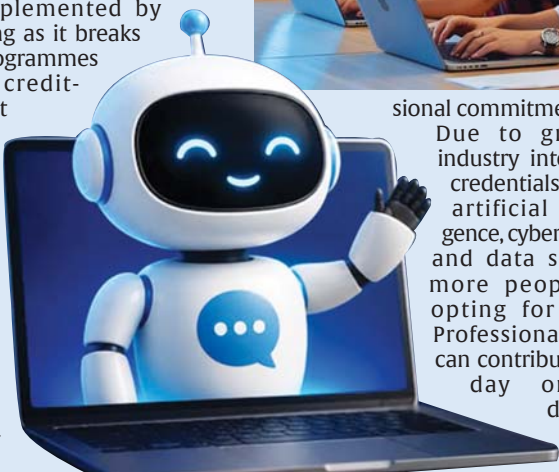
The advantages of micro-credentials extend well beyond employability for learners, as these programmes offer greater flexibility in designing personalised learning journeys based on industry demand, career aspirations, and evolving interests. For example, a management graduate may develop expertise in business analytics or digital marketing, while a student pursuing engineering may complement their degree with credentials in AI ethics or cloud computing.

Universities are playing a vital role in embedding stackable credentials within academic programmes, collaborating with industry to co-design curricula as

well as leverage digital platforms to deliver high-quality education at scale. While preserving the academic depth that remains central to higher education, these initiatives strengthen the connection between classroom learning and workplace expectations.

Micro-credentials are not a substitute for traditional education, which provides a strong foundation. Universities will increasingly serve as lifelong learning partners, allowing students to return for specialised certifications, accumulate credits and build expertise as careers and technologies evolve.

Higher education is evolving to keep in touch with changing societal and economic needs as India continues its journey towards becoming a global knowledge and innovation hub. Micro-credentials and modular learning represent a significant step in making education more flexible, personalised and future-ready. Universities can prepare graduates for lifetime learning, innovation and meaningful contribution towards society by embracing these approaches and a strong academic foundation. Through this, universities will help in building a resilient talent ecosystem capable of driving India's growth and global competitiveness for decades to come.



No Iran talks planned, Hormuz open despite strike: Trump

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump said on Tuesday the US has no talks planned with Iran but insisted the Strait of Hormuz remains "open and operating," despite limited traffic and a reported strike on a ship exiting the waterway.

Earlier this week, Trump also threatened to bomb Oman as the country sought a deal with Iran to manage shipping traffic through the strait, two regional officials said on Tuesday, a day after Trump leveled the threat. Iran says the waterway will not be reopened until the US meets its conditions.As talks between Iran and Oman con-



tinue, a projectile hit a ship in the strait and Iran-backed Houthi rebels claimed they fired drones at an oil refinery in Saudi Arabia.

As Oman and Iran say they are nearing a deal to reopen

the Strait of Hormuz, Trump said on social media Tuesday that the US blockade of Iranian ports remains "in full force and effect," and asserted that all water mines have been removed. Trump

posted a map depicting the strait as US territory.

Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi appeared to respond to Trump's post.

"Just as Trump correctly wrote the name of the eternal Persian Gulf, soon his delusion regarding the Strait of Hormuz will either be corrected or we will correct the delusions of this deluded man," he wrote on X.

The Trump administration has told Oman it opposes parts of the yet-to-be-announced deal, according to officials briefed on the US position. Those include joint Iranian and Omani management of the passage's exit route and the collection of

voluntary fees from vessels, even if the money is used for security and maritime environmental protection.The officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to talk to journalists.

The White House on Tuesday referred to Trump's remarks in the Oval Office and declined to comment further about Oman.

The Egyptian Foreign Ministry said Tuesday that the Iranian-Omani deal could pave the way for Washington and Tehran to return to negotiations for a "comprehensive and permanent deal that addresses all concerns and enhances regional security and stability." The state-

ment came after a meeting between Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty and Omani counterpart Badr al-Busaidi. But it did not address Trump's latest threat against Oman.

The 60-day negotiating period ended this week between the U.S. and Iran with no clear end to the war in sight. Ship traffic through the Strait of Hormuz dropped significantly last week with confirmed crossings falling 19.5 per cent to 95 transits. Only three vessels made it through the waterway on Sunday, according to shipping data platform Kpler.

The ships used the Iranian-designated route, with no crossings recorded through

the Omani routes. Crossings through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait increased 6.7 per cent to 254 transits, while so-called dark transits, in which ships turn off the transponders that broadcast their location, fell from 40 to 16, Kpler said.

An unidentified projectile damaged the engine room of a ship in the Strait of Hormuz near Oman and "resulted in a crew casualty," according to the British military's UK Maritime Trade Operations center.

The maritime monitoring agency did not release any details about the ship or its cargo, and it was not clear whether the crew member was killed or wounded.

Ukraine fires 800 drones in massive strike on Russia



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian forces staged one of their biggest drone attacks on Russia since Moscow's invasion more than four years ago, firing almost 800 drones just two days after launching a similar salvo, officials said on Tuesday.

Meanwhile, a Russian missile strike on a village in Ukraine's northeastern Kharkiv region killed at least 10 people and wounded eight others as the barrage demolished homes, officials said .

The warring countries are locked in an escalating duel of long-range aerial strikes. Fighting on the roughly 1,250-kilometre (780-mile) front line in eastern and southern Ukraine is restricted by large numbers of drones and ground robots threatening troop movements, and neither side is making significant battlefield progress, analysts say.

Over the past year Ukraine has devised and deployed domestically produced long-range drones for strikes deep inside Russia.

Its drone technology has impressed Governments and defence manufacturers around the world.

Opening arguments set in Meta's federal child safety trial

BARBARA ORTUTAYAP
■ Oakland

Opening arguments are set to kick off on Tuesday in a pivotal trial for Meta Platforms in a California federal court.

Attorneys general from California, Colorado, Kentucky and New Jersey are seeking extensive financial damages plus changes to how the company operates Facebook and Instagram. Twenty-nine states sued the tech giant in 2023 over child safety and privacy — the other 25 will go to trial later. The company also faces lawsuits in state courts.



The lawsuit accuses the social media giant of contributing to the youth mental health crisis by knowingly and deliberately designing features that get children addicted to its platforms.

It also argues that Meta routinely collects data on children under 13 without

their parents' consent, in violation of federal law. "This week, we're in court with the largest consumer protection lawsuit in American history.

We'll show a jury that Meta concealed what it knew about the harm its products cause young people because looking away was more profitable," said Kentucky Attorney General Russell Coleman in a statement.

Meta said it believes it has a strong case. "We are proud of our record in protecting teens on our platforms and the amount of effort that we've put into developing protections

over the years, even before these cases were ever filed, and continuing to the present day. We look forward to showing the judge and the jury those facts in court," the company said in a statement.

US District Judge Yvonne Gonzalez Rogers in Oakland will oversee the proceedings, which are expected to last six to eight weeks, with Zuckerberg and other executives. Gonzalez Rogers, appointed to the bench by President Barack Obama in 2011, has overseen a bevy of complex, high-profile cases involving Big Tech. (AP)

Putin hosts Myanmar's leader for talks on deepening their relationship

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Moscow

President Vladimir Putin on Tuesday hosted the head of Myanmar's military-backed Government, who visited Russia on a trip to boost their cooperation.

Speaking at the start of the talks with President Min Aung Hlaing, Putin noted both countries have cooperated on foreign policy and security issues and developed economic projects.

They have held joint military drills and developed plans for Russia to build a nuclear power plant, a seaport, oil refineries and other facilities in Myanmar.

The visit is the latest in a series of trips by Min Aung Hlaing to foreign countries, including neighbouring China, India, Laos and Thailand as he seeks to strengthen international recognition and regain diplomatic standing with other countries.

Despite the visits, Myanmar has remained largely isolated internationally



since the military seized power from the elected Government of Aung San Suu Kyi in February 2021. Western nations have imposed economic and political sanctions in response to the takeover by the military, which he led, and its violent repression of the opposition, which has seen the deaths of thousands of civilians and given rise to a civil war.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001 for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	07260323	One Coach Set of Air Spring Assembly	542 Set	15.09.2026
02	16260391	Vertical Damper 400 KG	2202 Nos	16.09.2026
03	07261825	Face Plate, for Buffer Plunger	6352 Nos	16.09.2026
04	08261252A	Track Feed Battery Charger	2270 Nos	21.09.2026
05	07261086	Helical Spring For Axle Box Guide Arrangement	852 Nos	13.10.2026
06	07261496	Water Tank Assembly	273 Nos	21.10.2026

Note: 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No. 36/2026-2027 Dated: 18.08.2026 2854/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

REGD. AD / DASTI / AFFIXATION / BEAT OF DRUM / NEWSPAPER PUBLICATION / BY ALL PERMISSIBLE MODES
OFFICE OF THE RECOVERY OFFICER DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I, DELHI
4th FLOOR, JEEVAN TARA BUILDING, PARLIAMENT STREET, NEW DELHI – 110001
SALE PROCLAMATION

TRC/264/2022
PROCLAMATION OF SALE UNDER Rule 38, 52(2) OF THE AXIS BANK Vs. ASHISH BATHLA
TAX ACT, 1961 READ WITH THE RECOVERY OF DEBTS DUE TO BANK AND FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS ACT, 1993.

(CDT) ASHISH BATHLA S/O JAGAN NATH BATHLA, QU 187 B, PITAMPURA, NEW DELHI – 110034
ALSO AT: INTERGLOBE TECHNOLOGY QUOTIENT PVT. LTD., 3RD FLOOR, BLOCK A, SUSHANT LOK – I, GURUGRAM – 122001.

ALSO AT: C – 21, NALANDA COLONY, HASTINAPUR ROAD, MAYANA, MEERUT – 250401

The under mentioned property will be sold by Public E-auction sale on 10/09/2026 for recovery of sum of **Rs. 26,28,922.00 (RUPEES TWENTY-SIX LACS TWENTY-EIGHT THOUSAND NINE HUNDRED TWENTY-TWO ONLY)** plus interest and cost payable as per Recovery Certificate issued by Hon'ble Presiding Officer, DRT-I (less amount already recovered, if any), from ASHISH BATHLA

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTY

No. of lots	Description of the property to be sold with the names of the co-owners where the property belongs to defaulter and any other person as co-owners.	Revenue assessed upon the property or any part thereof	Details of any other encumbrance to which property is liable	Valuation also given, if any, by the Certificate Debtor	Claims, if any, which have been put forward to the property, and any other known particulars bearing on its nature and value.	Reserve Price below which the property will not be sold	EMD 10% of Reserve price or Rounded off
1.	2.	3.	4.	5.	6.	7.	8.
1	PROPERTY i.e. FLAT NO. RED	Not known	Not known	No	Not known	Rs. 47,04,750	Rs. 4,70,475

BELL 1503 MADHUBAN BAPUDHAM SCHEME CODE 818, GHAZIABAD, U.P. IN RESIDENTIAL PROJECT DEVELOPED BY THE GHAZIABAD DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY (GDA)

1. Auction/bidding shall only be through online electronic mode, through the e-auction website i.e. <https://baanknet.com> (<https://baanknet.com>)

2. The intending bidders should register the participation with the service provider well in advance and get user ID and password for participating in E-auction. It can be procured only when the requisite earnest money is deposited in prescribed mode below.

3. EMD shall be deposited latest by till 05:00 PM on 07/09/2026 in Wallat Bank Asset Auction Network (BAANKNET) (<https://baanknet.com>) EMD deposited thereafter shall not be considered for participation in the e-auction.

4. In addition to above, the copy of PAN Card, Address Proof and Identity Proof, E-mail ID, Mobile Number, in case of the company, copy of board resolution passed by the Board of Directors of the company or any other document confirming representation/attorney of the company and the Receipt/Counter file with copy deposit should reach to the said service provider through e-auction website by uploading softcopies on or before till 05:00 PM on 07/09/2026 and also hard copies alongwith EMDs deposit receipts should reach at the Office of Recovery Officer-I, DRT-I, Delhi by 07/09/2026. It is also held that earnest money of unsuccessful bidders shall be returned back in the respective accounts of such bidders through the same mode of payment.

5. Prospective bidder may avail online training from service provider:

Particulars	Details
Name of Auction Agency	Bank Asset Auction Network (BAANKNET)
Contact person	Mr. Uday Jadhav (Authorised Officer of Baanknet)
Helpline Nos.	+91-9820878255
Helpline Email Address	Support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com ; 8291202220
Bank officer	ROHIT BALUNI (AUTHORISED OFFICER) 9891388406, rohit1.baluni@axisbank.com

6. Prospective bidders are advised to visit website <https://baanknet.com> (<https://baanknet.com>) for detailed terms & conditions and procedure of sale before submitting their bids.

7. The property shall not be sold below the reserve price.

8. The property shall be sold in 01 lot, with Reserve Price as mentioned above lot.

9. The bidder shall improve offer in multiples of Rs. 20,000/- during entire auction period.

10. The property shall be sold "AS IS WHERE BASIS" and shall be subject to other terms and conditions as published on the official website of the e-auction agency.

11. The highest bidder shall have to deposit 25% of his final bid amount after adjustment of EMD already paid in Wallat Bank Asset Auction Network (BAANKNET) (<https://baanknet.com>) by immediate next bank working day by 4:00 P.M. through Demand Draft/Pay Order favouring Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi A/C. T. R. C. No. 264/2022.

12. The successful bidder/auction purchaser shall deposit the balance 75% of sale consideration amount on or before 15th day from the date of sale of the property. If the 15th day is Sunday or other Holiday, then on immediate first bank working day through Demand Draft/Pay Order favouring Recovery Officer, DRT-I, Delhi A/C. T. R. C. No. 264/2022.

13. In case of default of payment within the prescribed period, the deposit, after deduction the expenses of the sale, may, if the undersigned thinks fit, be forfeited to the Government Account and the defaulting purchaser shall forfeit all claims to the property or the amount deposited. The property shall be resold forthwith, after the issue of fresh proclamation of sale. Further the purchaser shall also be liable to make good of any shortfall or difference between his final bid amount and the price for which it is subsequently sold.

14. Schedule of auction is as under:-

Particulars	Date	Time
Service of notice by all modes	07/08/2026	—
Inspection of property	21/08/2026	From 1:00 pm to 4:00 pm
Last date of receiving both physical bids alongwith proof of earnest money and uploading documents of auction agency portal	07/09/2026	Up to 05.00 pm
Date and Time of E-Auction:	09/09/2026	Between 12:00 Noon to 1:00 pm

15. The Recovery Officer has the absolute right to accept or reject any bid or bids or to postpone or cancel the e-auction without assigning any reasons.
Issued under my hand and seal of this Tribunal on this 14/07/2026.

RAVINDER KUMAR TOMAR
RECOVERY OFFICER-I
DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL – I, DELHI

SVC CO-OPERATIVE BANK LTD.
(Formerly The Shamrao Vithal Co-op Bank Ltd.)

(Regional Office At : First Floor, E-25, East of Kailash, New Delhi-110065 and one of its branch office at : 25/36, Ground Floor, East Patel Nagar, New Delhi – 110008.

POSSESSION NOTICE

WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SVC Co-operative Bank Limited., (earlier known as The Shamrao Vithal Co-operative Bank Ltd) under The Securitization & Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 11.06.2026 under Section 13 (2) of the said Act, calling upon Borrowers/Mortgagor (1) Mr. Sher Singh Rana (alias S.S. Rana), S/o: Dhonkal Ram Rana, Principal Borrower, at: 192, Block GH-8, Paschim Vihar, Sahyog Apartment, West Delhi, Delhi-110087 (2) Mrs. Mandeep Rana W/o. Mr. Sher Singh Rana, Co-Borrower/Mortgagor, at: House No. 192, Block GH-8, Paschim Vihar, Sahyog Apartment, West Delhi, Delhi-110087, and to repay the amount mentioned in the said Notice being **Rs. 21,52,287.18 (Rupees Twenty-One Lakh Fifty Two Thousand Two Hundred Eighty-Seven and paise Eighteen only)** as on 31.05.2026, together with interest at contractual rate from 01.06.2026 as mentioned in the said notice plus legal costs/charges etc till the date of payment, within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

The Borrowers/Mortgagor having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrowers/Mortgagor and the public in general that, the undersigned Authorised Officer of SVC Co-operative Bank Ltd., has taken **SYMBOLIC POSSESSION** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under Section 13 (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with the Rule 8 of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 on this 14.08.2026.

The Borrowers/Mortgagor in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of SVC Co-operative Bank Limited., (earlier known as The Shamrao Vithal Co-operative Bank Ltd) for an amount of **Rs. 21,20,019.18 (Rupees Twenty-One Lakh Twenty Thousand Nineteen and paise Eighteen only)** as on 31.07.2026, together with interest at contractual rate from 01.08.2026 at contractual rate plus legal costs/charges etc. till the date of entire payment.

The Borrower's/Mortgagor's attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE PROPERTY

Equitable Mortgage of All that piece and Parcel of Free hold Aza DDA Built up LIG Flat No.188 on 3rd floor (area measuring 45 Sqmtr), Pocket- GH-8, Area Zone G-17 situated at Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110087.

owned and possessed by Mrs. Mandeep Rana W/o. Mr. Sher Singh Rana.

Mr. Gopa Ranjan Panigrahy
Senior Manager & Authorised Officer
For SVC Co-operative Bank Ltd.

Date : 19.08.2026
Place : New Delhi

यू०पी० स्टेट हैण्डलूम कारपोरेशन लिमिटेड
कबीर भवन जी०टी० रोड कानपुर नगर - 208005

अभिवृत्ति की अभिव्यक्ति सम्बन्धी विज्ञप्ति (Expression of Interest)

राज्य सरकार के उपक्रम उ०प्र० राज्य हथकरघा निगम लि०, कबीर भवन, जी०टी०रोड, कानपुर के निम्नलिखित विक्री केन्द्रों / भवनों को निगम की सहभागिता योजना के अन्तर्गत किराये पर देने हेतु इच्छुक है। निगम की सम्पत्तियों को सहभागिता योजना/ किराये पर लेने हेतु इच्छुक संस्थाएं / इकाईयाँ/ समितियाँ निम्नलिखित विक्री केन्द्रों / सम्पत्तियों का मौका मुआयना कर जहाँ जिस स्थिति में है, से सम्बन्धित अपना प्रस्ताव दि० 03.09.2026 को 4.00 बजे तक सम्बन्धित प्रभारी विपणन परिक्षेत्र को प्रस्तुत कर सकती है। प्रत्येक प्रस्ताव के साथ रू० 11,00,00/- (न्याह्र हजार) मात्र का डिमाण्ड ड्राफ्ट जो "U.P.State Handloom Corporation Ltd.," के नाम से देय होगा, संलग्न करना अनिवार्य होगा। यह धनराशि किसी भी दशा में वापस नहीं होगी। विक्री केन्द्र की स्थिति का 70 प्रतिशत क्षेत्रफल ही सहभागिता योजना / किराये पर दिया जायेगा। पृथक-पृथक सम्पत्तियों के प्रस्ताव निर्धारित प्रारूप पर पृथक-पृथक प्रस्तुत करना होगा।

क्र० सं०	सम्पत्तियों का विवरण एवं पता	स्थानीय स्तर पर प्रारूप प्राप्त करने हेतु सम्पर्क सूत्र एवं प्रस्ताव प्रस्तुत करने हेतु प्रभारी का नाम एवं मो०न०
1.	यू०पी० हैण्डलूम विक्री केन्द्र, शाँप न० जी-10, ट्रांसपोर्ट अधीनस्थ दिल्ली, डिस्ट्रिक्ट सेंटर जनकपुरी, नई दिल्ली	नज़रत अनुभागी, मुख्यालय, कानपुर मो०न० 7985790550
2.	भू-भाग, सयन हथकरघा विकास परियोजना, लाकड़ी फाजलपुर, मुरादाबाद	-उपराक्त-

नियम एवं शर्तें :-

1. प्रत्येक प्रस्ताव के साथ रू० 11,00,00/- (न्याह्र हजार) मात्र का डिमाण्ड ड्राफ्ट का धरोहर धनराशि निगम के पक्ष में डिमाण्ड ड्राफ्ट संलग्न करना अनिवार्य है, जो किसी भी दशा में वापस नहीं होगा।

2. विक्री केन्द्र हेतु गत तीन वित्तीय वर्ष की बेलेंस सीट जो वख़ / हस्तशिल्प से सम्बन्धित व्यवसाय का हो, प्रस्ताव के साथ संलग्न की जायेगी।

3. विक्री केन्द्र हेतु संस्था का जी०एस०टी० पंजीकरण, पैन नं० व प्रोप्राइटर /सचिव / अध्यक्ष का आधार नं० संलग्न करना अनिवार्य होगा।

4. संस्था के गतवर्ष का आई०टी०आर० संलग्न करना होगा।

5. उपरोक्तानुसार धनराशि का डिमाण्ड ड्राफ्ट एवं वांछित कागजात संलग्न न होने पर प्रस्ताव मान्य नहीं होगा।

6. नियमानुसार पंजीकृत अनुबन्ध-पत्र हस्ताक्षरित कराया जायेगा।

7. अलग-अलग सम्पत्ति का प्रस्ताव / आवेदन पत्र अलग-अलग लिफाफे में तथा लिफाफे पर सम्पत्ति का नाम लिखना होगा।

8. आवेदन पत्र/प्रस्ताव में किराये /सहभागिता की प्रतिमाह धनराशि (जी०एस०टी० अतिरिक्त) स्पष्ट रूप से अंकित की जायेगी।

9. प्रस्ताव किसी भी स्तर पर निरस्त करने का अधिकार प्रबन्ध निदेशक का होगा।

10. किसी प्रकार के विवाद की स्थिति में न्याय क्षेत्र कानपुर नगर होगा।

(प्रमोद चन्द्र ठाकुर)
प्रबन्धक निदेशक

STATE BANK OF INDIA

BRANCH OFFICE: HOME LOAN CENTRE, A1/24, JANAKPURI, NEW DELHI-110058

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002. Hereinafter Called "ACT"

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MR. ROHIT S/O SUBHASH	Make & Model: GRAND VITARA SMART HYBRID SIGMA Registration No: DL-9C-BG-5504 Engine No.: K15CN7371425 Chassis No.: MBJTXYK1LSRB21877	14/08/2026 Date of N.P.A. 26.02.2025	Rs.12,84,582/- (Rupees Twelve Lakh Eighty Four Thousand Five Hundred Eighty Two Only) as on 14.08.2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Sd/- Authorized Officer,
DATE: 14.08.2026 PLACE: NEW DELHI State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Janakpuri, New Delhi

STATE BANK OF INDIA

BRANCH OFFICE: HOME LOAN CENTRE, A1/24, JANAKPURI, NEW DELHI-110058

DEMAND NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002. Hereinafter Called "ACT"

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DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower	Details of Properties / Address of Secured Assets to be Enforced	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MR. MD. SHAMSHER S/O MD. BAZIR	Make & Model: THAR ROXX AX7L D AT RWD Venue 1.2 KAPPA MT S(O) + Registration No: DL-7CY5992 Engine No.: KYS4L44934 Chassis No.: MA1UN2KY752L32270	07/08/2026 Date of N.P.A. 05.08.2026	Rs.19,80,288/- (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Eighty Thousand Two Hundred Eighty Eight Only) as on 07.08.2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Sd/- Authorized Officer,
DATE: 07.08.2026 PLACE: NEW DELHI State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Janakpuri, New Delhi

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Digital FASTag local pass extended to 121 toll plazas

National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has extended the facility of online FASTag 'Local Passes' to 121 toll plazas across the country, an official statement said on Tuesday.

Eligible commuters can subscribe the monthly local pass online through the Rajmargyatra Mobile App, eliminating the need for physical visits to toll plazas and manual submission of supporting documents, the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways said.

The first Digital Local Pass facility was launched in July 2026 at the Mundka-Bakkarwala toll plaza on Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) in Delhi.

The initiative is aimed at making national highway travel more seamless and citizen-centric by leveraging technology to enhance transparency and efficiency of the tolling operations.

Under the Digital Local Pass framework, those residing within 20 km radius of an eligible toll plaza can apply for the Local Pass through Rajmargyatra Mobile App. (PTI)

Uzbekistan keen to import steel from India

Uzbekistan is keen to import steel from India, a strategic move aimed at significantly lowering logistics costs for the landlocked Central Asian nation, an industry official said on Tuesday. The landlocked country imports around 1 million tonnes of steel, including TMT bars, from China, the official said. The logistics cost from China to Uzbekistan via sea route is as high as USD 100 per tonne, in addition to the actual steel cost.

The country is keen to import steel from India via a shorter, alternative route. It would lower its logistics cost, the industry member said, adding that the Uzbekistan Metallurgy Association has also signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Indian Steel Association (ISA) in this regard. "Both associations will work towards manufacturing, technology, environment, sustainable growth, logistics etc and to facilitate interaction for the purpose of advancing mutual understanding among the steel industries of India and Uzbekistan," he added.

The development assumes significance as the government has been encouraging Indian steel players to enter new markets to increase steel exports. India is the world's second-largest steel producer.

According to market research firm BigMint, India's total steel exports stood at 9.1 million tonnes (MT) in 2025-26. The major export regions were the European Union (EU), Vietnam and the Middle East, specifically the UAE. The Indian Steel Association (ISA) is the steel sector's policy advocacy body. Its members include major steel producers such as Tata Steel, JSW Steel, Jindal Steel and AMNS India. (PTI)

India has ₹1 lakh crore digital connectivity opportunity: BIF President

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has a digital connectivity opportunity worth ₹1 lakh crore at a conservative estimate, which can be largely achieved through satellite communication services, a senior official of industry body BIF said on Tuesday.

Speaking on the sidelines of the 10th edition of India Satcom 2026, Broadband

India Forum (BIF) President TV Ramachandran said an analysis of data published by the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (Trai) shows that around 50 crore or more people in rural India are still not connected to broadband.

"There are more than 50 crore people who are still unconnected, mostly in rural and remote parts of the country. Even if we con-

GE Aerospace is utilising artificial intelligence solutions to boost inspection, analytics and maintenance for aircraft engines, with the turnaround time for engine work being reduced by at least five days, according to company executives.

The engineers at the company's John F Welch Technology Centre (JFWTC) in Bengaluru are playing a key role in advancing new services and maintenance tech-

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | AUGUST 19, 2026

UP: Shedding the legacy of a laggard State

I come from a village in eastern Uttar Pradesh and have watched the State change from very close quarters. I remember the days when the monsoon made everyday life difficult, when women cooked on smoky chulhas, when families struggled to keep firewood dry, and when electricity was more absence than presence. Today, LPG connections under the Ujjwala scheme, household toilets and a steadier power supply have altered these basic textures of rural life. For me, these are not just government schemes; they are changes I can see in the lives of people I have known since childhood.

I also remember travelling from my village to Azamgarh—barely 21 kilometres away—by ekka or in an overcrowded jeep, a journey that could swallow almost an entire day. Roads and connectivity have improved considerably since then. Getting to Azamgarh, Mau, Ballia and other parts of eastern Uttar Pradesh is far easier now, with better roads and more transport options. What once felt like an ordeal has become part of everyday life.

When people talk about Uttar Pradesh's transformation, the conversation usually turns to expressways, airports, investment and industry. All of that matters, but for me development is also about these smaller, quieter changes: cleaner kitchens, dignity for women, children studying under electric light, and families travelling with less struggle. I have seen where Uttar Pradesh started, and I can see where it stands

today. That is why, for me, this transformation is not a statistic or a political talking point—it is something I have lived through.

Once counted among India's BIMARU States, Uttar Pradesh was long associated with weak law and order, scant investment, poor connectivity and limited employment opportunities. Over the past eight-and-a-half years, that picture has changed rapidly and decisively. Under Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the State is steadily building an identity as one of the country's principal growth engines. Aligning itself with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a Viksit Bharat by 2047, the Yogi Government has set itself ambitious targets: a one-trillion-dollar economy by 2030 and a six-trillion-dollar economy by 2047. In 2025-26 the State's economy has already crossed 419 billion dollars, a provisional figure, with the next milestone of 500 billion dollars set for 2026-27, before the larger goal of one trillion dollars comes into view.

Charting the Road to 2047 with Citizen Participation

The Government has not confined itself to a four- or five-year horizon. It has drawn up a roadmap that runs all the way to 2047. Under the framework of "Samarth Uttar Pradesh-Viksit Uttar Pradesh @2047," three core missions have been identified: holistic development, economic leadership and cultural renaissance, resting on the twin pillars of economic strength, creative strength and life strength. In plainer terms, the goal is to expand investment and employment, bring in new technologies and lift the quality of life for ordinary citizens. What stands out is that the process has been made participatory, village-level consultations were held, online feedback and QR-code responses were invited, experts were consulted, and nearly five million

suggestions from the public have already reached the Government.

Twelve Strategic Sectors Powering the Economic Leap

To make the journey from one trillion to six trillion dollars, the government is leaning on twelve key sectors: agriculture and allied activities, livestock, industry, infrastructure, IT and emerging technologies, tourism and culture, urban and rural development, balanced regional growth, social welfare, education, health, and security with good governance. The intent is explicit—development should not stay confined to Noida, Lucknow or the big cities. Villages, farmers, youth, women and small entrepreneurs are meant to be partners in this growth, with particular attention being paid to bringing Purvanchal and Bundelkhand into the accelerated trajectory.

Restoring Investor Confidence through Law and Order

No industrialist puts money into a State without first being assured of a safe environment. From the outset, the Yogi government made law and order its top priority and adopted a zero-tolerance policy towards the mafia and organised crime. Official figures show action has been taken against illegal assets worth more than 1.44 lakh crore rupees. Under "Operation Conviction," more than 1.04 lakh convicts have been sentenced. Over 2.21 lakh police personnel have been recruited, and more than twelve lakh CCTV

jobs. More than thirty-six sectoral policies have been framed for industry, and the Nivesh Mitra portal has streamlined clearances. Work is under way on investments exceeding 40,000 crore rupees across the Agra, Aligarh, Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi and Chitrakoot nodes of the Uttar Pradesh Defence Industrial Corridor, while the manufacture of BrahMos missiles in Lucknow is adding further weight to the state's emerging industrial identity.

Positioning Uttar Pradesh at the Forefront of AI and Emerging Technologies

Factories and roads alone will not carry the economy forward in the years ahead. Artificial intelligence, semiconductors, data centres, deep-tech and blockchain are set to become major engines of employment and enterprise, and these domains have been built into the government's roadmap accordingly. AI-related centres are coming up in Lucknow and Kanpur, while Noida and Lucknow are being positioned as major hubs for data centres and Global Capability Centres. The government's target is to train four crore young people in new technologies by 2047 and prepare them for a global workforce.

Integrating Farmers and Rural India into the Growth Narrative

A large share of Uttar Pradesh's population still lives in villages and depends on agriculture, and the one-trillion-dollar goal cannot be reached without carrying farmers along. Mega Food Parks, cold-chain infrastructure, Primary Agricultural Credit Societies and Farmer Producer Organisations are being used to link cultivators directly with markets, with a parallel push to boost agricultural exports. Alongside this, the state is preparing to advance in solar energy and green hydrogen, aiming to meet 50 per cent of its energy needs from renewable

sources by 2030.

Advancing Inclusive Growth: Women, Education and Healthcare

An economy is only as strong as its reach into ordinary households, which is why education, health and women's economic participation have been woven into the development roadmap. Through Operation Kayakalp, Atal Residential Schools and the expansion of medical colleges, facilities in education and healthcare have been strengthened considerably. Women's labour-force participation rate has risen sharply, from 13.5 per cent to 34.5 per cent, and the Government is aiming to take this to 50 per cent by 2030 and to parity with men by 2047.

Beyond the Trillion-Dollar Milestone: Towards a Six-Trillion-Dollar Horizon

For the Yogi Government, a one-trillion-dollar economy is not the destination but a waypoint. The larger goal is to turn Uttar Pradesh into a six-trillion-dollar economy by 2047, raise per-capita income to approximately 26 lakh rupees, and lift the State's share in national GDP to 20 per cent. The path to that destination runs through law and order, investment, expressways, airports, industry, agriculture, technology, education and health. Having left its old BIMARU identity firmly behind, Uttar Pradesh is now advancing as a genuine growth engine of the nation. The one-trillion-dollar milestone is simply the next station on this transformative journey.

I have seen Uttar Pradesh change since my childhood, and I can clearly see where it stands today. For me, therefore, this transformation is not just a statistic or a political narrative, it is a change I have personally witnessed.

The author is an IRS officer currently serving as Joint Commissioner of Customs for the North Eastern Region (NER), Shillong. He writes on current affairs and contemporary topics

El Niño unlikely to hurt kharif output much: Chouhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The impact of El Niño on kharif production this year is unlikely to be significant, as the gap in sown area continues to narrow despite deficient rainfall in a few pockets, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said on Tuesday.

Speaking at a press conference after an event, Chouhan said kharif crops have received adequate rainfall for growth in most parts of the country, bringing down the number of vulnerable districts from 262 to around 100.

"We don't see a huge impact of El Niño except in some places. The situation by and large remains good.

Rainfall was sufficient to meet the full water needs of the crops," he said.

The lag in sown area, which stood at 11 per cent last week, has since narrowed and is expected to reduce further, the minister said. "We still have to review

the situation as it is changing daily," he added.

Asked about the effect of deficient rains on kharif output, Chouhan said, "As of now, we see no impact." He noted that states such as Karnataka and Telangana were facing water short-

ages, but maintained that overall sowing had been good, with only localised impact expected.

The minister also said the Seeds Bill and the Pesticides Management Bill were ready in draft form and would be tabled in Parliament in the next session as part of the government's agriculture sector reforms.

As of August 14, sowing of kharif crops had been completed on 92 per cent of the average sown area, with total sown area at 1,016.57 lakh hectares — 2 per cent lower than a year ago. Sowing, which typically gathers pace with the onset of the southwest monsoon in June, was delayed this year due to El Niño conditions.

Assam Cabinet passes new hydrocarbon policy

Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma addressing media on Tuesday

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Assam Cabinet on Tuesday passed passes new hydrocarbon policy, to incentivise exploration for finding new reserves. Addressing a press conference after a Cabinet meeting here, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said that a new hydrocarbon policy was approved in order to give incentives to exploration of minerals and crude even if there are no findings.

"The crude happening in Assam is all from old discoveries. In the last 20 years, we have not found any new minerals because we have not done any exploration. There is a risk in exploration as they may not result in findings and all investment will be useless then," he added.

In order to create a positive environment, the State Government will give incentives like GST rebate or subsidised land lease agreements, Sarma said.

"We have been producing around 4 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT) of crude annually. If we don't have new reserves, this will start declining after 10 years," he added.

"The Cabinet also approved setting up of the Youth Empowerment and Welfare Department. With this, Assam will probably become the first state to have a dedicated youth department," Sarma said. The proposed department, which will start functioning from September 17, will look after all issues related to the youth, including the Employment Exchange, he added.

GE Aerospace taps AI to cut engine maintenance turnaround time

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

nologies to improve engine durability, reliability, and time on wing for the airlines.

The Bengaluru team is helping with AI-enabled inspection and maintenance technologies as well as with next-generation propulsion technologies, including hybrid-electric propulsion.

Also, it supports the deployment of the 360 Foam Wash process that is used to remove dust and dirt from engines across MRO (Maintenance, Overhaul and Repair) shops. JFWTC will be completing 26 years in September.

When asked whether Artificial Intelligence (AI) is helping manage the supply chain issues, GE Aerospace in India's Gurram V Rao said, "AI is a big enabler," and added that with the forecasting ability, the turnaround time for engine work is getting reduced by around five days.

Sensex tanks 493 points as crude jumps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Market benchmark indices ended lower on Tuesday, with the Sensex falling 493 points and the Nifty dropping to the 24,154.90 level, as elevated crude oil prices and fading hopes of a diplomatic breakthrough in West Asia weighed heavily on investors' sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex was down 492.70 points, or 0.63 per cent, to settle at 77,235.46, registering its third day of decline. During the fag-end of trade, it tanked 493.8 points, or 0.63

Index	High	Previous Close	Close	Low	Open
NSE NIFTY	24,269.65	24,287.65	24,154.90	24,154.90	24,223.85
BSE SENSEX	77,575.21	77,728.16	77,235.46	77,234.36	77,418.97

per cent, to 24,154.90. The 50-share NSE Nifty declined for the sixth day, sliding 132.75 points, or 0.55

Consultancy Services, and Hindustan Unilever were among the major laggards.

Axis Bank, Power Grid, Mahindra & Mahindra, and Bajaj Finance were among the winners.

The BSE MidCap Select index declined 0.46 per cent, while the SmallCap Select index was up 0.24 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, Focused IT tanked 1.84 per cent, IT Realty (1.28 per cent), PSU Bank (1.04 per cent), Consumer Durables (0.81 per cent), FMCG (0.67 per cent), Metal (0.47 per cent), and Capital Goods (0.47 per cent).

MidSmall Private Banks

Quality Tilt, MidSmall Private Banks, Hospitals and Healthcare were the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, went up 0.17 per cent to \$91.02 per barrel.

"Crude oil remained the primary drag on market sentiment, while rising US bond yields and weak global cues prolonged the risk-off trend in Indian equities. Investor anxiety increased as hopes for a Middle East resolution faded following the expiration of the temporary US-Iran ceasefire, heightening concerns about renewed inflation," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

PROSPECT



The Archery Association of Assam extends its support to the Chief Minister's Relief Fund.

SRM University-AP, APDC sign MoU to accelerate drone technology and innovation



SRM University-AP, Amaravati, and Andhra Pradesh Drones Corporation (APDC) have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to strengthen drone technology, research, innovation, skill development, and real-world deployment in Andhra Pradesh. The MoU was signed in the presence of Hon'ble Union Minister for Civil Aviation Shri K Rammohan Naidu and Bastipati Nagaraju Panchalingala, Member of the Lok Sabha, highlighting the growing importance of drone technology in the state's emerging technology and innovation ecosystem.

Speaking on the collaboration, Dr Vinayak Kalluri, Registrar, SRM University-AP, said, "Drone technology is evolving rapidly and has the potential to transform sectors ranging from agriculture and infrastructure to disaster management and healthcare. This MoU represents SRM University-AP's commitment to building meaningful partnerships that connect academic excellence with national and regional development priorities."

Adya Singh of St Stephen's College is winner of Online Rounds crosswords expedition

Bihar Foundation National Inter-College Crossword Expedition (NICE) 2026 concluded its last E Round. Adya Singh of St Stephen's College, Delhi, and V K Sai Gayatri from BITS Pilani Hyderabad Campus took the top honours in Round E.

The NICE Overall and NICE Round-E brought together some of India's finest young crossword enthusiasts, with participants representing leading universities, engineering institutions, colleges and professional institutes. Besides Adya and Gayatri the national winners include Arnab V Raju from IIT Delhi and Shrawon Dey from IIT Guwahati, while the zonal winners are Aman Kumar from Government Engineering College, Vaishali; Divyam Jain again from IIT Delhi, Shivam Kumar Jha, IIIT Senapati, Ashish CT of IIT Madras and Anju Sengar from Government College, Joura, Morena.



SC directs CBI to examine all ED allegations against Indiabulls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the CBI to examine all the six allegations flagged by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) related to alleged dubious transactions involving Indiabulls Housing Finance Limited (IHFL) and related entities. The controversial real estate and financing firm Indiabulls has changed its name as Sammaan Capital and claimed change in share-holding pattern.

On July 28, the top court had pulled up the CBI and Delhi Police's Economic Offence Wing (EoW) for being silent on allegations of dubious transactions involving IHFL, terming their conduct "shocking" and saying it appeared to be a "case of quid pro quo". On Tuesday, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions of Additional Solicitor General SV Raju, appearing for the probe agencies, that the ED referred to six allegations,



and five aspects are being probed by the EoW.

The law officer said so far as the sixth issue, pertaining to the alleged routing of ₹1,575 crore, is concerned, the CBI has filed an application before a special PMLA (Prevention of Money Laundering Act) court in Mumbai seeking nod to probe. The bench directed the special judge in Mumbai to decide the CBI's application for further investigation within two weeks after it takes up the plea on August 24.

"The CBI shall thereafter submit a progress/status report to the Supreme Court," the bench directed. The court also noted that so far as the EoW probe was

concerned, it has given clean chit in all the five allegations probed by the Delhi Police agency.

The EoW was of the opinion that further investigation was not advisable.

Favouring a holistic view of the probes conducted so far by the EoW, the bench directed the CBI to independently inquire into the five allegations already looked into by the EoW, irrespective of the conclusions. During the ED probe, Indiabulls promoter Sameer Gehlaut has left the country to Europe in 2021.

"The CBI is directed to inquire into the five other allegations contained in the ED complaint irrespective of the opinion or report of the Delhi Police EoW and

India-UK trade pact to open global markets for Haryana's industries and services sector: Saini

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The India-United Kingdom Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) has opened new opportunities for Haryana's industries, MSMEs, farmers, exporters and services sector to expand in international markets. The agreement, which came into effect on July 15, 2026, provides nearly 99 per cent of India's exports with duty-free access to the UK market, covering almost 100 per cent of the trade value.

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi is strengthening trade relations with major and influential countries as part of the vision to make Viksit Bharat by 2047. The agreement between India and the UK is also a result of this



vision and marks a significant leap forward for India in the field of international trade. It will benefit all states of the country, particularly Haryana's industries.

He said that with the implementation of the agreement, Haryana, a state with strong manufacturing, agriculture, automobile, engineering, textile and ser-

vice sectors, is expected to gain significantly. The agreement will enable Haryana's products to reach the large UK market at more competitive prices and help the state's exporters integrate with global value chains.

The Chief Minister said that the major sectors likely to benefit from the agreement include textiles and

apparel, leather and footwear, gems and jewellery, chemicals, engineering products, auto parts, machinery, pharmaceuticals, processed food products, handicrafts and ceramic products. Prior to the agreement, these products attracted tariffs ranging from 4 to 70 per cent. With zero-duty access to the UK market, the competitiveness of products from these sectors will increase, providing direct benefits to Haryana.

Saini said that Haryana's textile and home furnishing industry in Panipat, automobile and auto-parts industry in Gurugram-Manesar, engineering and manufacturing sector in Faridabad, as well as agriculture and food-processing industries across various districts of the state, can take advantage of this opportunity.

Rajnath flags off NCC Girls' high-altitude trek Aparajita



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh flagged off the All India Girls High Altitude Long Trek 'Aparajita — Parang La 2026', a flagship adventure activity of the National Cadet Corps (NCC), during an event in New Delhi on Tuesday. The trek will traverse the Parang La Pass (5,578 metres, 18,300 feet), connecting the Spiti Valley of Himachal Pradesh with the Changthang region of Ladakh and is regarded as one of the country's most challenging high-altitude trekking routes.

The team will be led by three women officers representing the three services. 28 girl cadets are participating in the expedition, with an average age of 19 years, the youngest participant being just 16 and a half years old. In his address, Raksha Mantri termed the participation of young girls in such a challenging high-altitude expedition as a powerful testament to the courage, determination and growing capabilities of the women of the country.

The expedition team, accompanied by officers, medical staff, instructors and support personnel, will undertake the approximately 250-km trek over 30 days through some of the most remote and challenging terrain in the Himalayas. The route of the expedition includes Kibber, Dumla, Thaltak, Bongrojen, Parang La Pass, Dak Karzong, Norbu Sumdo, Kiangdom and Korzok, traversing high-altitude deserts, glaciers, snow-fields and river valleys.

Extending his best wishes to the team for a safe and successful trek, Rajnath Singh stated that such expeditions play an important role in developing leadership qualities, mental resilience, discipline and self-confidence among the youth. He commended the selected cadets

for their physical and mental preparation, emphasising that the trek would be a life lesson for them in resilience, confidence and self-discovery.

"The cadets would return from Parang La with not only memorable experiences but also a deeper understanding of their own inner strength," he hoped.

The defence minister exhorted the team members to keep 'safety', 'environment' and 'interaction with local communities' as their priorities throughout the expedition. "Strictly follow the guidance of instructors, avoid unnecessary risks, and adopt a zero-waste approach to protect the Himalayan ecology. Engage respectfully with local communities, understand their culture & traditions, and learn from their experiences. The expedition would become a defining milestone in your lives and inspire you to remain 'Aparajita' at every stage of life," he told the cadets.

Highlighting the growing achievements of NCC cadets in adventure activities across land, water and air, Singh lauded the girl cadets for demonstrating the spirit of 'Nari Shakti' by leading from the front. On the participation of cadets from pan-India NCC Directorates, he asserted that their diverse languages, cultures and backgrounds, united by a common mission, exemplify the spirit of 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat'.

Director General, NCC Lieutenant General Virendra Vats, and other senior officials of NCC & the Ministry of Defence were present on the occasion. The expedition is being conducted in two phases. A preparatory and acclimatisation trek was undertaken in the Bhaba-Pin Valley sector, following which the final team of NCC Girl Cadets was selected on merit.

ONGC connects Khoraghat Gas to North East Gas Grid, boosting regional energy access

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Limited (ONGC) successfully commissioned gas evacuation facilities at Khoraghat GGS-1 in Golaghat district, Assam, on Tuesday.

The facility enables surplus associated natural gas from the Upper Assam Shelf to be processed and evacuated through the North East Gas Grid (NEGG) developed by Indradhanush Gas Grid Limited (IGGL).

The development complements the commissioning of the Dergaon-Dimapur Pipeline, which has connected Nagaland to the North East Gas Grid and the National Gas Grid. The new connectivity will facilitate utilisation of nearly 1 lakh Standard Cubic Metres (SCM) of gas per day from ONGC's Jorhat asset.

ONGC is also developing hook-up facilities at Jantapathar and Kasomarigaon to connect additional producing fields of Jorhat Asset with the North East Gas Grid. These projects will further augment gas availability, reduce flaring and strengthen the gas-based economy of the region.

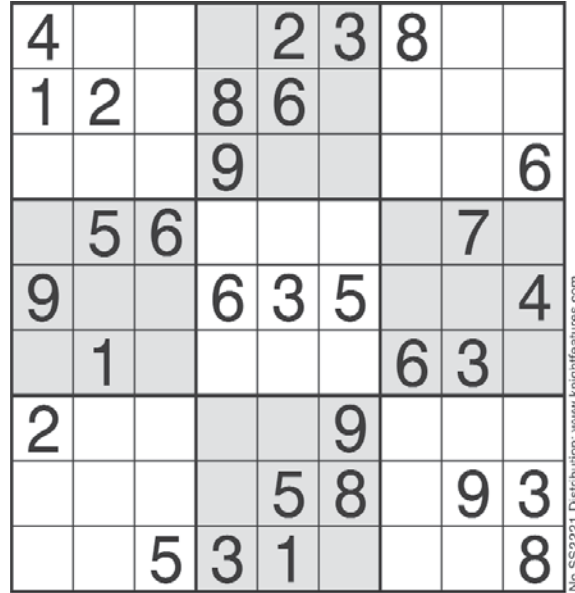


The improved gas availability will also create opportuni-

ties for households, industry, transport and power, while

supporting the economic and infrastructure development of Assam and the wider North-East. Together, the infrastructure strengthens gas connectivity across the region and advances the vision of developing the North-East as a key growth engine of India and a more integrated gas-based economy.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (18.8.26)								
5	4	2	6	7	9	1	8	3
6	7	3	8	1	2	9	5	4
8	9	1	5	3	4	7	2	6
7	1	8	3	4	6	2	9	5
3	2	6	9	5	7	8	4	1
4	5	9	1	2	8	6	3	7
2	6	5	7	9	3	4	1	8
1	8	4	2	6	5	3	7	9
9	3	7	4	8	1	5	6	2

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | AUGUST 19, 2026



ACROSS

- 1 Fish for the trout swimming around Birkenhead (6)
- 7 One's little mate with a place across the road (8)
- 8 A frontier row? (4)
- 10 Being simply whacked, unable to avoid defeat (6)
- 11 As you may demand, is packed in tins (6)
- 14 Through having no luck, perchance (3)
- 16 It'll give you the news on the 4th of July (5)
- 17 Regarded as having vision (4)
- 19 Search and rob of a weapon (5)

DOWN

- 1 Voice of a boy of three? (6)
- 2 Teased a bit, maybe by the Editor (6)
- 3 Rent to some sailors (4)
- 4 How a mortise and tenon can be considered (7)
- 5 Such defence is obviously inoffensive (5)
- 6 Tryingly irritable (5)
- 8 Perfect ending to "King Kong", as on video (4)
- 9 Always five short (3)
- 12 Take the diocesan view (3)
- 13 Threw a pest out of Preston's north end (5)
- 15 Princely testaments? (5)

- 21 Flirt with many a friend (5)
- 22 How one might deny being frigid? (5)
- 23 Short engagements (4)
- 26 Nero, for instance, was in a right state! (5)
- 28 He'll throw nothing out of the back door! (3)
- 29 New to being employed by the UN (6)
- 30 Come round when given another loan? (6)
- 31 King who went away with heavy heart (4)
- 32 Traveller interested in a new place (8)
- 33 Delivery of a herbal extract to a northern city (6)

- 18 In Canada, it's more than a kingdom (5)
- 19 The type to show little gratitude (3)
- 20 It's smart to go by air (3)
- 21 Finished being served by a houseworker (4,3)
- 22 Needs to be in phase (3)
- 23 Club player (6)
- 24 The thought I had for every one (4)
- 25 One easily painted? (6)
- 26 Draws the line unwaveringly (5)
- 27 Mother has an afterthought - a complaint (5)
- 28 Diminutive whistler (3)
- 30 After some errors, he's simply finished (4)

SOLUTION (18.8.26)			
ACROSS	19. Scram	DOWN	15. F-aint
1. Stick	20. Dren-Ch.	2. The box	16. Dyf-ed
6. Ditch	22. On-Ce	3. Co-gen-t	18. Can-o-e
9. O-Hskin	24. Set	4. Kiri(gly)	21. Re-si-de
10. Fei-g-n	25. Pointed	5. Ascot	22. Onside
11. A-cute	26. Store	6. Di-Agra-m	23. Cellar
12. Bough	27. Divot	7. Inch	25. Prime
13. Worn out	28. Billy	8. Cutter	26. Some
15. Fed	29. Mermaid	12. Butch	28. B-in
17. Exit	30. Pet-er	13. Weeds	
18. Canary	31. Nears	14. Rivet	

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
e-TENDER CALL NOTICE No.EM/PED-19/2026
No.EM/PED/TECH-09/25/295 Date.10/08/2026
Name of the work: Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of CCTV Surveillance System along the Perimeter wall of Port Prohibited area of Paradip Port Authority. Estimated Cost: Rs.4,25,21,844/- Last date & time of submission of bid: dt.16/09/2026 up to 16:00 Hrs. Refer our website for details <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (E), PED-III, Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/20/2026-2027 dt. 17.08.2026

Invitation For Bids (IFB)

The Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Assam Skill University Project (ASUP) cum Registrar, Assam Skill University (ASU) ("the Purchaser" invites online bid from eligible bidders for **the below mentioned Packages** at Assam Skill University:

#	Package No.	Package Name	Date of Publication		Deadline for Submission	
			Date	Time	Date	Time
1	GS02/ASU/TEC/096	Analog & Digital Communication Lab	19 August 2026	10.00 Hours (IST)	19 September 2026	14.00 Hours (IST)
2.	IT06	Examination Management System (EMS)	19 August 2026	10.00 Hours (IST)	19 September 2026	14.00 Hours (IST)

Interested bidders may download and submit their bids electronically using the e-Procurement portal <https://assamtenders.gov.in/>.

Sd/-
CEO, ASUP cum Registrar, ASU

DIPR/CF/PIO/1623/19-Aug-26

राष्ट्रीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान, कुरुक्षेत्र
NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY, KURUKSHETRA
(Under the Ministry of Education, Govt. of India)
KURUKSHETRA-136119 (Haryana)

Advt. No. 26/2026

WALK-IN-INTERVIEW

National Institute of Technology, Kurukshetra requires qualified and experienced person for engagement as Training & Placement Officer (01-UR) on contract basis. Interested candidates may appear for **Walk-in-Interview on 27.08.2026 at 11:00 AM** in the Board Room of the Golden Jubilee Administrative Building of the Institute along with duly filled application form, all originals certificates along with one set of self-attested copies of certificates, a recent Passport size photograph and an original identity proof for verification.

The persons may **report at 09:00 AM** on the above date in the Board Room for verification of documents.

For more details, please visit our website: www.nitkkr.ac.in.

Sd/-
Registrar Incharge

BRIEFLY

Tero Entertainment launches 3x3 Quest India 2026



Tero Entertainment Public Co Ltd. officially launched Quest India 2026 3x3 basketball, as a first step in bringing the world's fastest-growing urban sport to India.

It is backed by the Basketball Federation of India (BFI) and endorsed by FIBA. Unlike traditional five-on-five basketball, 3x3 is played on a half-court with a relentless 12-second shot clock. Games last just 10 minutes, or end the moment a team hits 21 points. It's a fast-paced, action-packed, constantly moving high-energy game designed around skill and technique. With DJs spinning throughout FIBA 3x3 events and fans sitting right on the baseline, the sport naturally blends elite athleticism with street culture.

Since its Olympic debut at Tokyo 2020, 3x3 has rapidly evolved. It captivated audiences at Paris 2024, is set to expand from eight to 12 teams at the Los Angeles 2028 Games, and remains a staple of the Commonwealth Games.

Kicking off with the Quest event on September 12-13, 2026, at DLF Promenade - Emporio, the inaugural event will fuse elite, intense 3x3 competition with music, interactive fan zones, and the distinctive urban energy that has made the format a global phenomenon and an Olympic sport. (PTI)

Chess has fascinated me for a long time: Gerard Pique



World Cup-winning Spanish footballer Gerard Pique has revealed that he has long been fascinated by chess and said the ambition to take the sport to a new level was one of the key reasons he joined Global Chess League franchise American Gambits as a strategic shareholder.

The fourth edition of the Global Chess League (GCL) will be held from September 3 to 13, with six franchise teams featuring some of the world's leading grandmasters and champions competing in a rapid, mixed-gender format.

"Throughout my career, I've always been interested in projects that rethink how sport connects with fans. Chess has fascinated me for a long time because of its depth, its global appeal and the incredible mental strength it demands," said Pique, the 39-year-old former Barcelona stalwart widely regarded as one of the greatest defenders of his generation, who played a key role in Spain's 2010 World Cup triumph. "What attracts me to American Gambits is the ambition to take chess to a new level and its long-term vision for the sport. I'm pleased to join as a strategic shareholder and wish the team every success in the season ahead," he added. Backed by a group of shareholders that includes former India cricketer Ravichandran Ashwin, American Gambits will enter their third GCL season with a strong lineup featuring Javokhir Sindarov, Nihal Sarin, Daniil Dubov, Bibisara Assaubayeva, Sara Khadem and Marc'Andria Maurizzi. (PTI)

Unnati credits her father-cum-coach Upkar for her rise in badminton

SAMOJYOTI S CHOUDHURY
■ New Delhi

Rising Indian badminton star Unnati Hooda has credited her rapid ascent in the sport to her father and mentor, Upkar Hooda, who sacrificed his career to train her full-time and is now guiding her from the coach's corner at her debut BWF World Championships.

Upkar, a former university-level player, quit his government college job to travel with his daughter for tournaments, even as she shifted her base to Chhotu Ram Stadium Badminton Academy in Rohtak to polish her skills under coach



Parvesh Kumar. However, till date her father remains her biggest inspiration.

"I'm not forced (into badminton). Of course, definitely there is a massive contribution of my family and my dad. He quit his job as well. So I

India vs Pak: Knockout dream, survival on line in WC clash

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen (Netherlands)

India will look to extend its decade-long unbeaten run against Pakistan and seal a place in the second round of the FIH Men's Hockey World Cup when the arch-rivals clash in a high-stakes Pool D match in Amstelveen today.

India, with three points from two matches, needs at least a draw to progress, while Pakistan, with one point, must win to keep their campaign alive. England have already qualified for the next round after winning both their matches.

India opened their campaign with a 3-1 win over Wales but suffered a 2-4

defeat against world number 3 England after conceding three goals in the second half.

Defensive lapses and an ineffective penalty-corner conversion rate will be the areas of concern for India coach Craig Fulton.

Pakistan, meanwhile, drew 3-3 with Wales after losing 1-4 to England and will need a vastly improved performance to overcome their neighbours. Their penalty-corner execution and defence have been inconsistent so far.

India have enjoyed the upper hand in recent meetings and defeated Pakistan 7-1 and 4-3 in the European leg of the Pro League earlier this year. Pakistan's last win over



India came in the 2016 Champions Trophy.

The gulf in recent performances is also reflected in their recent international record. India have won medals at the last two Olympics, while four-time World Cup champions

round at stake, both teams will also have to keep their emotions under control.

India's most experienced player Manpreet Singh, with 419 caps, said his side would not underestimate Pakistan.

"The match against Pakistan will be good, but we are not underestimating them. They also have good drag-flickers, so we will have to avoid giving them penalty corners. We must also create opportunities and capitalise on them. We must focus on our natural game," Manpreet said. India will also hope to improve their penalty-corner conversion after scoring only once from four opportunities against England.

Pakistan captain Abu Bakar Mahmood, meanwhile, insisted that past records and rankings would have little bearing on the contest.

"Rankings or past performance don't matter in a match between India and Pakistan. The team that plays well on match day will win, and we know how important this match is for our hockey, so we will leave no stone unturned," he said. Pakistan's preparations have been far from ideal. They were embarrassed in their opening match against England when their penalty-corner protection equipment was left in the dressing room, while against Wales they squandered several opportunities before settling for a draw. (PTI)

Keep India away from early PCs: Pakistan legend Samiullah

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Amstelveen

Pakistan hockey legend Samiullah Khan has sounded a clarion call to his team, urging them to forge an impenetrable defensive wall and ensure they do not surrender penalty corners in the crucial opening quarter of their high-stakes FIH World Cup pool clash against arch-rivals India on Wednesday.

Pakistan need a win to keep their campaign alive, while India can progress to the next round with a draw.

"I would advise Pakistan captain to keep a compact defence and not concede any penalty corners to India in the first quarter," Samiullah, the current chief selector of



Pakistan, told, "My suggestion to the midfielders is to advance towards the goal instead of passing backwards. The forwards will have to score through diagonal and interchange passes," he said.

The two-time Olympic gold medallist, popularly known as the 'Flying Horse' for his speed

golden generation of Pakistan Hockey.

Samiullah also praised India's transformation since 2016, saying Pakistan needs a similar long-term vision.

"India improved its system, expanded its player pool, improved penalty corners and deep defence, and its players are now earning well. In Pakistan, our federations lack long-term vision and set small goals," he said.

The 74-year-old also lamented the fading intensity of the India-Pakistan rivalry.

"Earlier, India and Pakistan would play Olympic and Asian Games finals and there would be huge hype. In 1978 and 1982, 20,000 to 35,000 spectators would watch us," he further added.

Tejaswin, Divya and Gayatri among Arjuna awardees

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Sports Ministry on Tuesday decided against bestowing the coveted Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna award on any athlete for the year 2025, while unveiling a significantly pruned list of 17 Arjuna awardees after an unprecedented re-evaluation of the selection panel's recommendations made more than six months ago.

Hockey star Hardik Singh was considered for the country's highest sporting honour by the selection panel headed by former Supreme Court Judge Arun Kumar Mishra but eventually fell out of contention. The last time that the country did not have a Khel Ratna was 2014.

World Cup winning chess player Divya Deshmukh,



decathlete and high jumper Tejaswin Shankar and shuttler Gayatri Gopichand were among the 17 sportspersons named for the Arjuna Award on Tuesday.

Also on the Arjuna Award list were Grandmaster Vidit Gujrathi, Gayatri Gopichand's women's doubles partner Treesa Jolly, Glasgow Commonwealth Games silver-medallist boxer

Narender Berwal (+92kg), and young deaf rifle shooter Dhanush Srikanth. The selection committee this year had recommended 24 names for the Arjuna Award but the ministry approved only 17.

The awards were announced following massive delay with the ministry announcing a re-evaluation process to ensure only worthy names were honoured to

"preserve the integrity of the awards."

The 19-year-old Deshmukh is the first Indian woman to win the World Cup. Vidit Gujrathi was part of the gold-winning Indian team at the 2024 Chess Olympiad.

Tejaswin Shankar, who won a historic decathlon silver medal in Asian Games in 2023 and followed it up with a second-place finish in Asian Championships last year, recently won a bronze in the Commonwealth Games despite battling a knee problem. He was among the athletes who criticised the delay in the announcement of the awards calling it disrespectful towards athletes.

In 2024, a record 32 athletes were conferred the Arjuna award, which included 17 from para-sports.

Ariha hopes maiden gold in Asian aerobic gymnastics inspires others

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Manipur's Ariha Pangambam on Tuesday said she hopes her historic gold-medal triumph at the Aerobic Gymnastics Asian Championships, organised in the Philippines earlier this month, will inspire more young athletes in the future.

The 22-year-old Ariha became the first Indian to win gold in the senior women's individual event at the competition, organised from August 4-7, which she said was the culmination of her hard work over the last 12 years.

"Winning this medal felt very special because I was able to do something for my country, and I felt proud of myself," Ariha told. "But the more important thing is that I was



able to set an example and I hope I can inspire young gymnasts so that they can achieve this success like me in future.

"Winning the gold medal was an amazing feeling. When I heard our national anthem playing on the podium and received the medal, it meant a lot to me. At that moment, I felt proud because I had achieved some-

thing not just for myself, but for our entire country," Ariha added. Ariha said the biggest challenge was performing on a wooden floor, which was different from what gymnasts usually train on in India.

"The competition was quite challenging because the floor there was different from what we usually train on in India. They had a wooden floor,

whereas we normally train on rubber or interlocking mats," Ariha said. "Although India has one such floor, most gymnasts do not get the opportunity to train on it regularly. We only got one day of podium training before the competition, so adjusting to the floor was difficult not just for me, but for many gymnasts from India."

While Ariha wants to add more accolades to her career, she said a crucial point in her fledgling career was choosing aerobic gymnastics as her discipline. "I was able to achieve this because of the support of my parents and my coach. Through these 12 years of journey, there was a time that I was frustrated, and in panic and I got anxiety because I was not increasing the difficulty elements or the

skills that I wanted to achieve," Ariha said.

"I started with artistic gymnastics but after one-and-a-half years, I changed it to aerobic gymnastics. My coach suggested that because as a kid, I used to enjoy dance and music... it would suit me better if I change. Because, in aerobic gymnastics, we do it along with music, we express the music." "Even though we do have difficulty elements, they felt that it would suit me more, so I took up aerobic gymnastics. One thing in regards to my development was in skills, because, as I said, I was totally frustrated at one point of time because I was not seeing any improvement. But then I thought, why should I give it up?" Ariha added.

After cancer battle, Gustav back on badminton's biggest stage

ANKIT SHRESTHA
■ New Delhi

At 17 kilos lighter and with virtually no muscle left on his body, Gustav Bjorkler had to rediscover what it meant to be a badminton player.

Cancer had taken away his physical strength. Rebuilding it took time. But the Swedish shuttler never lost the belief that he would one day return to the court.

Bjorkler was diagnosed with myelodysplastic syndrome (MDS), a form of blood cancer, in 2018. After undergoing chemotherapy and a stem-cell transplant, he was declared healthy in 2019.

"I didn't have any muscle on my body at all. I was the



same height, but almost 15 to 17 kilos less. So I didn't have any physicality at all," Bjorkler told PTI Videos after his match. "It took some time to get these things back."

The experience changed more than just his body. Having once fought some-

thing far more important than a badminton match.

"Of course, it affects you mostly mentally, I think, and it gives you another perspective on life as a whole," he said. "You think of life in another way and you're quite happy just to be healthy and

to be able to live a normal life." That perspective has stayed with Bjorkler even as he returned to the demands of professional badminton. He said he never lost belief that he would overcome the illness and make his way back to the highest level.

"That was something that helped me quite a lot when I went through the sickness. It really helped me to really push and just make the best out of it," he said.

Today, he does not want the illness to define him.

Asked what he would like people to know about him beyond his cancer story, Bjorkler kept the answer refreshingly simple.

"I'm just a guy that likes to

play badminton and enjoying badminton life at the moment," he said. "I'm really, really blessed that I'm healthy now." His comeback is taking place against another challenge while trying to develop as an elite badminton player in Sweden, where the sport does not enjoy the kind of popularity like in some of Europe's leading badminton nations.

Bjorkler has moved to Copenhagen to find better training and sparring, a decision that he believes can help him take the next step.

"Badminton is of course not that big in Sweden so I made a move to Denmark. I live in Copenhagen, I practice there," he said. (PTI)

Praggnanandhaa draws with Caruana in round 7 of Sinquefield Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ St Louis (USA)

Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa played out a fighting draw with Fabiano Caruana of the United States with black pieces and remained joint second after the end of the seventh round of the Sinquefield Cup, part of the Grand Chess tour.

The draw took Praggnanandhaa closer to a spot for a berth in the grand finale of the Grand chess tour scheduled later this year. The Indian took his tally to four points out of a possible seven.

Wesley So of the United States continued with his



fine run in the tournament and drew with the super-solid Anish Giri of Holland to remain a half point ahead of nearest rivals. Along with Praggnanandhaa, Caruana and Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France share the second position with four points

apiece in their kitty.

With just two rounds remaining in the \$475,000 prize money tournament, as many as four players — Vincent Keymer of Germany, American duo of Levon Aronian and Sevan Samuels and World Championship contender Javokhir Sindarov — share the fifth spot on 3.5 points each. Giri is currently ninth on 3 points a half point clear with his compatriot Jorden Van Foreest Standing last. The result between Caruana and Praggnanandhaa was never in any serious doubt as Indian faced a rather early endgame in Ruy Lopez opening.

India on verge of big win over SL in 1st Test

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Galle

Backed by Rishabh Pant's quintessential 66, India's bowlers displayed ruthless efficiency to reduce Sri Lanka to 84 for four at stumps on the fourth day as the visitors positioned themselves for a massive victory in the first Test here on Tuesday.

Pant, Devdutt Padikkal (44) and KL Rahul (35) pulled in their combined weight to take India to 193 in their second innings, raising an improbable target of 372 in front of Sri Lanka, who are still 288 runs away from that mark. For the hosts, skipper Chandanajaya de Silva (31) and first innings century-maker



Sonal Dinusha (25) were manning the crease at close. For a better understanding of the huge mountain in front of Sri Lanka, the highest ever successful chase in Test cricket at the Galle stadium is

344 by Pakistan in 2022, and a 200-plus target was surmounted only twice at this venue since 1998. The weight of that unfavourable history on them was so evident when the

Lankans came out to bat in the fourth innings after a brief rain delay.

They looked cagey, and the first wicket did not take too long to come. Mohammed Siraj hurried Nishan Fernando into a pull, and the latter could not control the shot which was taken in the deep by Prasidh Krishna. Prasidh himself had a moment of joy soon when he ousted Kamindu Mendis. After setting Mendis up with three in-coming deliveries, Prasidh served one that went away and the left-hander nibbled it to Rahul in the cordon. Between those two strikes, left-arm spinner Manav Suthar dislodged Pasindu Sooriyabandara, who

came in as a concussion substitute for Dinesh Chandimal. Chandimal sustained an injury while fielding during the first session of the day, hitting his shoulder and head hard on the ground.

Chandimal was cleared of any injury in the subsequent scan, but could not clear the concussion test.

However, that chancy entry into Test cricket lasted just one ball, as Sooriyabandara was trapped leg before by Suthar who later added the wicket of Lahiru Udara to his burgeoning kitty.

Earlier, the Lankan bowlers were suitably rewarded with regular wickets for using the pitch and conditions to good effect. (PTI)

Australia drops Weatherald, recalls Renshaw after loss to Bangladesh

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mackay (Australia)

Australia's has dropped Jake Weatherald and recalled Matt Renshaw in a bid to stabilize the top order and try to level the two-match series after a shocking loss to Bangladesh in the first cricket test on the weekend.

Australia announced a 13-man squad on Tuesday, with only the one change for the second test in Mackay, in northern Queensland state, starting Saturday.

Weatherald was out for 23 in the first innings and didn't score in the second innings of Australia's nine-wicket defeat in Darwin, and aver-



aged 20.36 in his 12 test innings. Marnus Labuschagne, who scored 1 and 31, was retained in the squad despite concern over his form.

The 30-year-old Renshaw is a contender to open the innings for Australia with Travis Head in his latest comeback to the test lineup.

Renshaw made his debut in 2016 and played 11 tests before being dropped in 2018. He was recalled in 2023 for three tests but has only played in the shorter formats for Australia since then. He averages 29.31 with one century in 14 tests, but has only played one of his last 10 tests on Australian soil.

When Manjrekar criticised me, I found something to learn from it: Ashwin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The natural reaction to any criticism is anger, but Ravichandran Ashwin found Sanjay Manjrekar's harsh observations about his bowling to be constructive and worked harder in the following years to change his perception.

The former India and Mumbai batter-turned-pundit, known for his brusque takes on all things cricket, had criticised Ashwin's performance in his column after the off-spinner took only nine wickets in three Tests Down Under at a very poor average of 62 runs per scalp during the 2011-12 series. India lost that series 0-4. "After my first Australia tour, Sanjay Manjrekar wrote a long article. When I was returning, I read the whole thing, and after reading it, I got really angry. I actually felt bad. Anger was

just a reaction, but I felt really bad. But after that, I slept on the flight and let it go. Back then, I didn't talk to Sanjay much," Ashwin said on 'Jio Hotstar'. However, he realised that Manjrekar's analysis should be taken in the right spirit and that he could work on certain areas of his bowling and fitness.

"...after coming back home, I worked really hard for the next four years. I wasn't a gifted athlete. I worked very hard, and in 2015, he wrote another article saying that I was bowling so well now and that he wanted me to keep performing like that."

Ashwin, in fact, got hold of Manjrekar's number and messaged him about how he felt. "Then I asked for his number and messaged him that I had felt bad back then, but his article came to me like a guru and changed my life. Because there was substance in



what he said. So, if I ever get criticised, I just think about whether there's something to learn from it. If I feel there's something to learn, I take it."

Ashwin was an opener during his days in junior cricket but took



to off-spin in later years of age-group cricket after watching Harbhajan Singh perform brilliantly in Border-Gavaskar Trophy back in 2001.

"Under Dinesh Karthik's captaincy, I played Under-19 cricket for the

first time. Back then, I used to bat a bit, and didn't bowl as much. So, whenever I bowled, I used to bowl with Bhajju Pa's bowling action because I was genuinely a fan.

"When Bhajju Pa came onto the scene, every day I used to copy his action while playing gully cricket. And actually, his dismissal of Ricky Ponting, and the dismissal of Matthew Hayden while bowling from over the stumps, during the Border-Gavaskar Trophy, I watched all those matches very closely. "But I never thought I'd become an off-spinner. In my mind, it was always batting. But when he (Harbhajan) used to bowl, there was something about him, his character, his ability to stand up to everyone and take the fight. So, I really liked that generation. I was genuinely a fan of him, and from there, I never imagined I would come this far."

Eala-Aliassime, Svitolina-Monfils, Errani-Vavassori get US Open wild cards

BRIAN MAHONEY ■ New York

Rising women's star Alex Eala and Felix Auger-Aliassime, spouses Elina Svitolina and Gael Monfils, and two-time defending champions Sara Errani and Andrea Vavassori have been given wild cards into the U.S. Open mixed doubles tournament.

The U.S. Tennis Association on Monday set 11 of the 16 teams that will be in the championship, with six teams qualifying directly because of their combined rankings and five being given wild cards. Topping the field is the team of No. 1-ranked Aryna Sabalenka and 24-time men's Grand Slam singles champion Novak Djokovic, who have the lowest com-



bined singles ranking of any team that entered.

Also qualifying directly, in order of their rankings: Elena Rybakina and Taylor Fritz, Diana Shnaider and Daniil Medvedev, Iga Swiatek and Casper Ruud - the runner-up team last year - Belinda Bencic and Flavio Cobolli, and Amanda Anisimova and Learner Tien.

The remaining wild cards given Monday went to the teams of Leylah Fernandez and Frances Tiafoe, and Taylor Townsend and Alexander Zverev.

The first round and quarterfinals will be played Aug. 25, with the semifinals and final set for Aug. 26. All of the matches will be played either in Arthur Ashe Stadium or Louis Armstrong Stadium,

the two biggest venues.

Three remaining wild-card spots are still to be announced, and the final two teams in the two-day main draw will earn their way in through an eight-team qualifying tournament to be played Aug. 24.

The teams given spots in the qualifying tournament Monday: Katerina Siniakova and Henry Patten, Gabriela Dabrowski and Harri Heliövaara, Luisa Stefani and Neal Skupski, Aleksandra Krunic and Mate Pavic, Jelena Ostapenko and Marcelo Arevalo, and Erin Routliffe and Lloyd Glasspool.

Two more teams will be given wild cards into the qualifying tournament.

Eala, 21, earned her first career title two weeks ago at

the DC Open, becoming the first player from the Philippines to win a WTA Tour event, and has been drawing large crowds to her matches.

Monfils is at the opposite end of his career, with the popular Frenchman planning to retire after this season. Errani and Vavassori won the title in New York in 2024, but the Italians weren't sure they would even get to defend it after the USTA revamped the event last year in an effort to draw top singles players who had long been shunning mixed doubles. They were eventually given a wild card, becoming the only traditional doubles team in the event, and beat Swiatek and Ruud in the final. (AP)

Serena and Venus return to doubles and lose in Cincinnati

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Asan (Korea)

Serena and Venus Williams played their first doubles match together since the 2022 U.S. Open and lost a thriller, 2-6, 6-1 (10-8) to Marta Kostyuk and Peyton Stearns on Monday night at the Cincinnati Open.

The sisters nearly recovered from a 6-0 deficit in the match tiebreaker before a double-fault by Venus Williams ended their first doubles appearance in a non-Grand Slam event since the Italian Open in 2016.

"I thought it was fun," Serena said. "I thought it was special. We kicked off a little rust in the middle of the match and just, you know

(were) starting to feel it. I didn't come out here to win this tournament. Winning is obviously great. But in this position just, you know, having fun. It was really cool to be able to do this again."

Serena had been off the tour since 2022 before returning this summer at age 44. The sisters planned to play together at Wimbledon but had to withdraw after Serena injured her knee while losing her singles match. They entered Cincinnati as a wild card.

"Eventually we would find our way to each other," the 46-year-old Venus said about the decision to play doubles again. "It's our first time playing together in forever. It was great for us to get out



there and do it."

Kostyuk and Stearns, both 24, are playing in their first tournament together. Kostyuk is from Ukraine. Stearns grew up in the Cincinnati suburb of Mason,

where the tournament is played every year.

"I kind of expected it but it stung a little bit that this is my hometown," Stearns said about the pro-Williams sisters crowd. "I won't hold it against

anyone. The crowd was going for them but we used it to our advantage and flipped the script."

After dropping the first set, the Williams sisters rolled in the second to force a match tiebreak. Kostyuk and Stearns went ahead 6-0, but consecutive double-faults by Kostyuk helped the Williamses get within 8-7. It was 9-8 after Serena powerfully put away an overhead before Venus double-faulted.

"The crowd got the show," Kostyuk said. "They probably couldn't ask for anything better. At the end a tiebreak is a lottery. You never know which way it's going to go."

Venus and Serena have won 14 Grand Slam doubles titles and 22 total.

It is dream to play for Barcelona: Rodri set to seal transfer from Man City

TALES AZZONI ■ Madrid

Spain's World Cup-winning captain Rodri arrived in Barcelona on Monday to seal his transfer from Manchester City, saying it's a dream to play for the Catalan club.

Rodri was expected to undergo a medical on Tuesday as Barcelona and City exchanged documentation to finalize the agreement. Barcelona agreed to a deal worth 76.5 million euros (\$88.5 million), a person with knowledge of the transaction confirmed to the Associated Press on Sunday. The person spoke on condition of anonymity



because details of the transfer have not been made public. "Very happy to arrive. There have been some very intense days, but I'm happy that everything has been resolved," Rodri told reporters briefly. "For me it's

a dream to play for Barcelona. I'm excited about being with my teammates, many of them I already know. Now it's time to get to work and give my best."

The 30-year-old Rodri helped Spain secure its second World Cup title last month and will join international teammates Lamine Yamal, Dani Olmo, Pau Cubarsi, Gavi and Pedri at Barcelona. Rodri won the Golden Ball as the World Cup's best player. He had one year left on his contract at City. Real Madrid was also reportedly interested in signing Rodri, and he had loudly praised the Barcelona rival in the past. (AP)

Lakshya enters second round with fighting win

SAUMJOYOTI S CHOUDHURY
■ New Delhi



Garret Tan, who defeated Switzerland's Tobias Kuenzi 21-4 21-15. Sen started slowly as his less-fancied opponent kept him on his toes in the first game. (PTI)

When India avenged 1982 Asiad loss against Pakistan in their last WC meeting

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

Sixteen years ago, when India and Pakistan last met in a men's Hockey World Cup, the contest was more than just two arch-rivals facing each other.

It was about settling an old score. The venue was the Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium in Delhi, the same ground where Pakistan had inflicted a painful 7-1 defeat on India in the 1982 Asian Games final.

On February 28, 2010, India returned to the same venue and turned the tables, beating Pakistan 4-1 in the opening match of the World Cup. Later in the same year, they defeated the arch-rival in the Commonwealth Games at the same venue by a 7-4 margin.

For the captain in the 2010 World Cup, Rajpal Singh, the victory was the culmination of a promise he had made days earlier after India had lost to Pakistan in the Champions Challenge in



Salta. "After the defeat, when the team was cooling down, two Pakistani players came up to me and asked, 'What happened? You couldn't play today,' I replied, 'We'll talk to you on February 28, 2010,'" Rajpal told PTI. February 28 was the date of the World Cup opener between the two sides.

But when the big day arrived, the memories of 1982 added enormous pressure. "Pakistan had defeated us on the same ground in the Asian Games, so the pressure

was immense. We had a new coach Jose Brasa. But the team's preparation was good, so we overcame the pressure. That victory healed old wounds," said Rajpal, who played 147 international matches for India.

The victory also gave Shivendra Singh one of his most cherished memories in an India-Pakistan contest. Shivendra scored India's opening goal and, overcome by the atmosphere inside a packed stadium, saluted the supporters. (PTI)